

The Heart of Dhamma Practice 2.13

A Map Based on the Early Suttas, a Practical Workbook, and a Glossary of Pali Terms

[Current version here](#)

The ascetic Gotama taught only one thing: dukkha, the cause of dukkha, the cessation of dukkha, and the path to the cessation of dukkha.

“Whatever is subject to arising is subject to cessation.”

This English translation was produced with the assistance of AI and subsequently reviewed and edited by the author. It is not a professional translation and may still contain linguistic or interpretive inaccuracies.

In case of discrepancies, the original Russian version should be regarded as authoritative.

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How to Read This Document

This is a map, a set of checks, and a collection of practical exercises for investigating *dukkha*, *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, *bhava*, *anattā*, and *paṭiccasamuppāda* in one's own experience.

This document does not claim to be 100% accurate or complete. It may contain errors and imprecise formulations.

Pali terms are retained where a standard English rendering can easily distort their meaning. For example, *dukkha* means more than “suffering,” *taṇhā* is not simply any desire, *upādāna* is more than strong attachment, *bhava* means more than “existence,” and *anattā* is not a declaration that “I do not exist.”

The best way to use this text is to take one passage at a time and test it in daily life. If the practice becomes a source of tension, contempt, pride, or fear, something has been misunderstood. If it leads to greater clarity, gentleness, sobriety, letting go, and reduced reactivity, the direction is sound.

0. Preliminary Foundation: Health, Sobriety, and Values

The practice of Dhamma does not take place in a vacuum. The body, the psyche, trauma, habits, social environment, and values all condition whether practice is sound, safe, and free from avoidance. Before engaging in subtler work with *dukkha*, *taṇhā*, and *anattā*, it is therefore useful to examine this foundation honestly.

Area	What matters here	Practical criterion
Psychiatry and neurology	Severe disorders, neurological conditions, and states requiring medical care.	When there is a risk of self-harm, psychosis, severe insomnia, panic, or sudden deterioration, professional help is needed, rather than an attempt to endure heroically through practice.
Psychological health	Trauma, attachment patterns, emotions, and the capacity for kindness and connection.	Practice makes behavior gentler, more honest, and more responsible, not colder, prouder, or more detached.
Cognitive clarity	The ability to notice patterns and errors in thinking, projections, and self-deception.	Less dogmatism and fewer abrupt conclusions; more consistency and clarity.
Values	A shift away from personal gain toward what is beneficial, toward simplicity, and toward the Dhamma as the highest value.	Less preoccupation with status and pleasure, and greater interest in practice.
Self-observation	The skill of seeing body, feelings, mind, and <i>dhammā</i> as processes.	Instead of “this is what I am,” one begins to note: “a condition, feeling, craving, or impulse has arisen.”

Not every form of meditation is automatically a practice of liberation. Meditation may be used for stability, clarity, and reducing anxiety. In this document, the central criterion is: does the practice weaken *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, and *avijjā*, and lead toward the cessation of *dukkha*?

Meditation is better understood not as a mechanical algorithm, but as a living and, in some respects, creative process. The Buddha gave a method, a direction, and verifiable conditions: *sīla*, *sati*, *samādhi*, *paññā*, the abandoning of *taṇhā*, and the cultivation of *magga*. But there is no single fixed sequence guaranteed to lead to *Nibbāna*. The path cultivates conditions for the ending of craving and clinging. *Nibbāna* is not produced by a technique and is not a conditioned result.

Caution: meditation should not replace treatment where medical care is needed. If practice intensifies alienation, insomnia, fear, obsession, or contempt for others, that is a warning sign.

1. Testing the Dhamma: Eight Criteria from AN 8.53

A good safeguard against spiritual self-deception is to look beyond appealing words to their results. [AN 8.53](#) provides a filter: what leads to dispassion, freedom, simplicity, and less strain may be recognized as being in accordance with the Dhamma and Vinaya (*Dhamma-Vinaya*).

Criterion	Meaning	Question for checking
<i>virāga</i> , not <i>sarāga</i>	Toward dispassion, not passion.	After practice, is there less attraction, passion, and dependence?
<i>visaṃyoga</i> , not <i>saṃyoga</i>	Toward release from bonds, not bondage.	Is there less of “I must obtain/prove/hold on to this”?
<i>apacaya</i> , not <i>ācaya</i>	Toward reduction, not accumulation.	Is there less mental proliferation, status-building, and accumulation of concepts?
<i>appicchatā</i> , not <i>mahicchatā</i>	Toward having few wishes, not many.	Is there less need for stimulation, recognition, validation, or special status?
<i>santuṭṭhi</i> , not <i>asantuṭṭhi</i>	Toward contentment, not discontentment.	Does a sense of sufficiency arise, so that one no longer feels compelled to keep improving conditions or seeking new experiences?
<i>paviveka</i> , not <i>saṅgaṇikā</i>	Toward seclusion, not constant company.	Does the mind seek less noise, argument, confirmation, and novelty?
<i>vīriyārambha</i> , not <i>kosajja</i>	Toward arousing energy, not laziness.	Is there energetic and steady effort without violence toward oneself?
<i>subharatā</i> , not <i>dubbharatā</i>	Toward being easy to support, not demanding or fastidious.	Is the person becoming less demanding in daily life and relationships?

If a teaching or practice increases dependence, fear, craving for status, harshness, a sense of specialness, or contempt for others, it should be thoroughly re-examined.

The complexity of a system does not prove that it leads closer to liberation. The criterion remains practical: are *lobha*, *dosa*, *moha*, *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, and *māna* becoming weaker?

How to Evaluate the Transmission of the Dhamma

The early suttas are the primary basis of this document. A text does not, however, become true merely because it carries authority.

In [MN 95](#), faith, preference, oral tradition, reasoning, and a view accepted after reflection may accord with the truth or may not. Until there is direct knowledge, it is more accurate to state honestly the basis of one’s understanding and not declare it the only possible interpretation.

In [AN 4.180](#), a report attributed to the Buddha, the Sangha, or learned elders is not to be accepted or rejected immediately, but compared with the suttas and Vinaya. It is also important to consider possible errors in transmission, later editing and interpolation, context, parallels in other canons, the intent of the sutta, the influence of tradition, distortions in translation, and so forth. One’s own experience helps test the practical meaning.

2. Doctrinal Core

This chapter provides a brief overview of the teaching before the following chapters examine its individual parts in greater detail.

The Four Noble Truths (*ariyasacca*)

1. *dukkha* - the unsatisfactory nature of conditioned experience.
2. *samudaya* - the source of *dukkha*: *taṇhā*.
3. *nirodha* - the cessation of *dukkha*: the fading away and abandonment of *taṇhā*.
4. *magga* - the path leading to the cessation of *dukkha*: the Noble Eightfold Path.

Dependent Origination: *paṭiccasamuppāda*

The twelve-link chain shows how some processes condition others:

avijjā → *saṅkhārā* → *viññāṇa* ⇌ *nāma-rūpa*
→ *saḷāyatana* → *phassa* → *vedanā*
→ *taṇhā* → *upādāna* → *bhava* → *jāti* → *jarāmaraṇa*, *dukkha*.

The Six Sense Fields (*āyatana*)

Experience unfolds through six internal sense fields and their corresponding objects:

- the eye and forms;
- the ear and sounds;
- the nose and odors;
- the tongue and tastes;
- the body and tactile objects;
- the mind and mental phenomena.

The general pattern of a sensory event is:

sense field + object → *viññāṇa* → *phassa* → *vedanā*.

This is how the twelve-link chain connects with immediate experience: what is seen, heard, felt, and thought.

The Five *khandhā*

What is experienced and can be appropriated as “I” and “mine” is examined in the suttas through five aggregates:

- *rūpa* - form;
- *vedanā* - feeling;
- *saññā* - perception;
- *saṅkhārā* - formative activities;
- *viññāṇa* - consciousness.

The problem is not these processes themselves, but clinging to them and appropriating them as “I” and “mine.” It is this clinging that sustains *dukkha*.

The Noble Eightfold Path (*ariya aṭṭhaṅgika magga*)

Group	Factors
<i>paññā</i> - wisdom	<i>sammā-diṭṭhi</i> - right view; <i>sammā-saṅkappa</i> - right intention.
<i>sīla</i> - ethical conduct	<i>sammā-vācā</i> - right speech; <i>sammā-kammanta</i> - right action; <i>sammā-ājīva</i> - right livelihood.
<i>samādhi</i> - development of collectedness	<i>sammā-vāyāma</i> - right effort; <i>sammā-sati</i> - right mindfulness/recollection; <i>sammā-samādhi</i> - right collectedness, defined in the standard formula as the four <i>jhānas</i> .

The factors of the path support and strengthen one another.

Eight Factors of the Path and Two Culminating Factors

In [MN 117](#), two further factors are given:

9. *sammā-ñāṇa* - right knowledge;
10. *sammā-vimutti* - right liberation.

In this discourse, the path of a disciple still in training has eight factors, while ten factors are named for one who has reached perfection. The final two should be understood as the culmination of the path:

sammā-samādhi → *sammā-ñāṇa* → *sammā-vimutti*.

A Map of *samādhi*: Jhānas, Formless Dimensions, and Cessation

1. the first *jhāna*;
2. the second *jhāna*;
3. the third *jhāna*;
4. the fourth *jhāna*;
5. the dimension of boundless space;
6. the dimension of infinite consciousness;
7. the dimension of nothingness;
8. the dimension of neither-perception-nor-non-perception;
9. the cessation of perception and feeling (*saññāvedayitanirodha*).

What matters is the depth of each attainment, recognition of its conditioned nature, and relinquishment of the corresponding support. Simply passing through all the attainments without wisdom and the cessation of clinging is not liberation.

The Five Hindrances (*nīvaraṇa*)

- *kāmacchanda* - sensual desire;
- *vyāpāda* - ill will, irritation;
- *thīna-middha* - dullness and drowsiness;
- *uddhacca-kukkucca* - restlessness and remorse;
- *vicikicchā* - doubt that obstructs practice.

The Seven Factors of Awakening (*bojjhaṅgā*)

- *sati* - mindfulness/recollection;
- *dhammavicaya* - investigation of phenomena;
- *virīya* - energy, diligence;
- *pīti* - joy, rapture;
- *passaddhi* - tranquility;
- *samādhi* - collectedness;
- *upekkhā* - equanimity.

The Three Unwholesome Roots

[Iti 50](#) names three roots of the unwholesome:

- *lobha* - greed, passionate attraction;
- *dosa* - aversion, hostility;
- *moha* - delusion, mental obscuration.

Lobha, *dosa*, and *moha* describe the roots of the unwholesome, whereas *avijjā*, *taṇhā*, and *upādāna* describe different conditions in the unfolding of *dukkha*. One triad should therefore not be used as a direct substitute for the other.

Additional Supports

- *mettā* - goodwill;
- *asubha* - contemplation of unattractiveness;
- *yoniso manasikāra* - wise direction of attention;
- *indriya-saṃvara* - restraint of the sense faculties.

3. The Field of Experience: *sabba* and the Six Sense Fields

In [SN 35.23](#), the Buddha limits “the all” to what is actually given in experience: the eye and forms, the ear and sounds, the nose and odors, the tongue and tastes, the body and tangibles, and the mind and mental phenomena.

For practice, this means beginning with what is experienced right now: what is seen, heard, or felt in the body, as well as feelings, thoughts, images, intentions, and reactions. There is no need first to settle whether “the world exists in itself,” and so forth. The practical question is simpler and more concrete: how does feeling arise from contact, how does craving arise from feeling, how does clinging arise from craving, and how can this be brought to an end?

The Six Sense Fields (*āyatana*)

Sense field	Object	Consciousness	Contact
Eye	form	visual consciousness	visual <i>phassa</i>
Ear	sound	auditory consciousness	auditory <i>phassa</i>
Nose	odor	olfactory consciousness	olfactory <i>phassa</i>
Tongue	taste	gustatory consciousness	gustatory <i>phassa</i>
Body	tangible object	bodily consciousness	bodily <i>phassa</i>
Mind	ideas, images, memories	mental consciousness	mental <i>phassa</i>

An important practical conclusion follows: a thought, concept, image, memory, or fantasy is just as much an object of practice as a sound or a bodily sensation. The mind can cling to these as well.

Here “the eye” means more than the anatomical organ or a fixed bodily entity. It is a changing, conditioned sense faculty participating in the process of seeing. In dependence on the eye and visible form, visual consciousness arises; the conjunction of these three is called contact, and contact conditions feeling. The other sense fields work in the same way.

In [MN 38](#), consciousness is compared to a fire that is named after its fuel: a wood fire, grass fire, or straw fire. Likewise, consciousness is designated according to the conditions on which it arises: visual consciousness arises in dependence on the eye and forms, auditory consciousness on the ear and sounds, and mental consciousness on the mind and mental objects. Consciousness here is not an independent bearer of experience; each type arises when the relevant conditions are present.

Mind as an Internal Sense Field

Within this map of experience, mind is neither a hidden master nor an eternal observer. It is one of the six internal sense fields. The eye encounters visible forms; the ear, sounds; the nose, odors; the tongue, tastes; the body, tactile objects; and the mind, mental phenomena.

Thoughts, images, memories, and concepts connected with what was seen, heard, or felt may become objects of the mental sense field. A sensory episode can therefore continue as an inner story: “this is a danger,” “this is about me,” “I must respond.” Here it is useful to distinguish contexts. *Mano* denotes mind as the sixth internal sense field; *viññāṇa*, consciousness of an object that arises dependent on conditions. It is useful to observe *citta* not as a permanent “mind,” but as a process that changes with conditions and always has a particular coloration. These terms do not denote three separate entities, but describe interrelated processes from different angles.

How “a Being” and “the World” Are Constructed

What we call “the world” is experienced through the six sense fields. What we call “a being” is constructed in relation to the five aggregates: body or form, feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness. The error begins not with the process of seeing or hearing itself, but with appropriation.

The visible becomes “what I see.” A feeling becomes “my feeling.” A thought becomes “my opinion.” A memory becomes “my story.” Under ignorance, “I,” “mine,” and “for me” are

added to what is seen, heard, felt, and thought. Conditioned experience thus becomes the basis of a personal story and further clinging.

Practice does not require denying what is seen, heard, or felt. It teaches one to see how “I” and “mine” are added to experience.

In this account, the mind is neither the creator of the world nor the first cause of *saṃsāra*. In [SN 35.82](#), the “world” is disclosed through the sense fields, the corresponding kinds of consciousness, contact, and feeling, which arise and cease according to conditions.

It is therefore more accurate to say not that the mind creates *saṃsāra*, but that the *saṃsāric* process is nourished when ignorance, craving, clinging, and formative reactions are present. Mind is part of this conditionality, not its master or source.

4. The Horizon of Practice: *Nibbāna* as *asaṅkhata*

Within the framework of the early suttas, *Nibbāna* should not be reduced to a trance, non-being, an absolute, a blank mental screen, a pleasant state, dissociation, or a meditative attainment that can be maintained. It is *asaṅkhata*: the unmade, the unconditioned, not arisen as a composite process. The Pali texts [Iti 43](#) and [Ud 8.3](#) speak of the unborn, the unoriginated, and the unmade, by virtue of which release from the born and made is possible.

In *Nibbāna* there is no *avijjā*, no *taṇhā*, and no *upādāna*. What matters here is precisely their absence, even potentially.

It is important to distinguish the following:

- Calming the mind is a valuable condition, but not liberation itself.
- The cessation of a particular chain is a useful small-scale experience of *nirodha*, but is not necessarily *Nibbāna*.
- Deep states of *samādhi* can support wisdom, but if one clings to them, they become a subtle form of *bhava*.
- *Nibbāna* is not appropriated as “my attainment.” If a new identity is built around liberation, there is already good reason for doubt.

Nibbāna Is Not a “True Self”

A misunderstanding may arise: the body is not “self,” feelings are not “self,” perception, formations, and consciousness are not “self,” so there must be a real “self” somewhere behind them. *Nibbāna* is then understood as a true essence, pure consciousness, and so forth. This is often conditioned by craving for existence.

But the Buddha examined the five *khandhā* not so that they could be rejected and another “self” found, but in order to recognize the mechanism of clinging itself. The five aggregates encompass the entire field of conditioned experience that the mind may take as “I” and “mine”: body or form, feeling, perception, formative activities, and consciousness.

Nibbāna is therefore neither an eternal “self” nor the annihilation of a “self.” There is nothing to annihilate: an independent self is found neither in any aggregate nor outside them. What ceases is not a self, but the craving, clinging, becoming, and *dukkha* that sustained the idea of a self.

Nibbāna should not be understood as a conditioned state of consciousness produced by a technique, maintained by effort, and then brought to an end. The early texts disclose it primarily through the cessation of craving, dispassion, cessation, and the unconditioned, without introducing a new entity, a “true observer,” or a subtler mode of existence.

Beyond Existence and Non-existence

The Buddha did not reduce liberation to the statement “I exist” or to the statement “I do not exist.” Both formulas still revolve around “I.” In the first, the mind seeks a footing in existence; in the second, a footing in non-existence.

Practice goes deeper. It shows how the very framework “I am” arises from ignorance, craving, clinging, and becoming. When ignorance is recognized as ignorance, this framework loses its nourishment. There is then no longer a need to seek salvation in either existence or non-existence.

Stages of Awakening and the Ten *saṃyojana*

In the suttas, stages of awakening are described primarily through the weakening or cutting of fetters (*saṃyojana*), not through the experience of unusual states. This is a map of release from clinging, not a set of titles and not a reason to build an identity around “my attainment.”

Stage	What changes	Practical meaning
<i>sotāpanna</i> - stream-enterer	The first three fetters are cut: <i>sakkāya-diṭṭhi</i> , <i>vicikicchā</i> , and <i>sīlabbata-parāmāsa</i> .	The view that the self is identical with one or more of the five aggregates, possesses them, contains them, or is contained in them; doubt concerning the Dhamma; attachment to rules and rituals.
<i>sakadāgāmin</i> - once-returner	The first three fetters are cut; sensual desire and ill will are noticeably weakened.	Reactions are still possible, but their strength, frequency, and power over the mind have already been substantially reduced.
<i>anāgāmin</i> - non-returner	The five lower fetters are cut, including <i>kāmacchanda</i> and <i>vyāpāda</i> .	Craving for sensual pleasures and the tendency toward aversion have completely ceased.
<i>arahant</i> - fully liberated	All ten fetters are cut, including <i>rūparāga</i> , <i>arūparāga</i> , <i>māna</i> , <i>uddhacca</i> , and <i>avijjā</i> .	Craving, clinging to <i>rūpa</i> and <i>arūpa</i> , conceit, restlessness, and ignorance have ceased; experience is no longer appropriated as “I” and “mine.”

In [MN 64](#), the absence of an overt manifestation of a fetter does not mean that it has been finally removed. The corresponding underlying tendency (*anusaya*) may remain and manifest when suitable conditions arise. This is illustrated by the example of an infant: a fully formed identity view, doubt, sensual desire, or hostility does not yet arise in the infant, but the corresponding tendencies have not been removed.

The term *saṃyojana* describes a defilement as a condition that sustains clinging and further becoming. The term *anusaya* denotes an unremoved predisposition that may temporarily remain unmanifest. The terms are closely related but not fully interchangeable. [AN 10.13](#) lists ten fetters, whereas [AN 7.11](#) lists seven underlying tendencies. The temporary absence of desire, hostility, or doubt therefore does not yet mean freedom from them.

A *sotāpanna* is described as one in whom the first three fetters have been cut. In practical terms, this may be understood as a profound and irreversible undermining of the footing on which “I” is built in experience. *Sakkāya-diṭṭhi* loses its power: the mind can no longer take the *khandhā* as “I,” “mine,” or “this is what I am” in the same naive way.

Avijjā, *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, and *māna* cease completely only in an arahant.

What Ceases in an Arahant

The cessation of *dukkha* in an arahant does not mean the disappearance of the body, sense faculties, contact, and feeling. As long as the arahant’s life continues, the five *khandhā* continue to function: seeing, hearing, bodily sensations, and pleasant, unpleasant, and neutral *vedanā* can arise. There may be bodily pain, fatigue, hunger, illness, and aging.

Practically, this can be expressed as removing “I” from all processes: body, feeling, perception, *saṅkhārā*, consciousness, and contacts continue to arise through conditions, but are no longer appropriated as “I” and “mine.” An arahant may therefore experience the first arrow, such as bodily pain or unpleasant contact, but the second arrow does not arise: mental suffering constructed from craving, resistance, fear, resentment, and conceit.

An arahant need not appear outwardly unusual, omniscient, continuously blissful, emotionless, or endowed with magical powers. Liberation is not determined by status, way of life, or miracles. What matters is the cessation of *avijjā*, *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, *māna*, and *bhava*.

No.	<i>Samyojana</i>	Meaning
1	<i>sakkāya-diṭṭhi</i>	identity view based on the five aggregates
2	<i>vicikicchā</i>	doubt that undermines confidence in the Dhamma and practice.
3	<i>sīlabbata-parāmāsa</i>	clinging to rules, vows, observances, and to the Dhamma as an end in itself.
4	<i>kāmacchanda</i>	sensual desire, attraction to sensual pleasures.
5	<i>vyāpāda</i>	ill will, hostility, rejection.
6	<i>rūparāga</i>	desire for subtle-material existence, clinging to <i>rūpa</i> levels.
7	<i>arūparāga</i>	desire for formless existence, clinging to <i>arūpa</i> levels.
8	<i>māna</i>	conceit, comparison, the subtle “I am.”
9	<i>uddhacca</i>	restlessness, subtle instability of mind.
10	<i>avijjā</i>	ignorance of the Four Noble Truths and the conditioned arising of <i>dukkha</i> .

It is useful to distinguish *sakkāya-diṭṭhi* from *māna*. *Sakkāya-diṭṭhi* is the view that body, feeling, perception, formations, or consciousness are “self,” belong to a self, are within a self, or contain a self. *Māna* is subtler: it is the habit of centering experience around “I am,” “I

experience,” “I understood,” “I am superior,” “I am inferior,” or “I am equal.” One might put it this way: after a flower is removed, its fragrance remains for a time. In the same way, after a coarse view of self has weakened, a subtle trace of “I am” may remain.

In [SN 22.89](#), Khemaka uses a closely related comparison: the residual “I am” is like the scent of a flower, which cannot be attributed separately to its petals, color, or pollen.

In [MN 22](#), the Buddha compares the Dhamma to a raft: the raft is needed for crossing over, not to be carried on one’s head after the crossing. In the same discourse, grasping the Dhamma wrongly is compared to seizing a snake by the wrong end. If the teaching is taken up for argument, status, self-assertion, or views, it may cause harm instead of liberation.

Even *sati*, *samādhi*, the *jhānas*, wisdom, and “my path” can become new objects of *upādāna* if the mind builds an identity around them.

Letting go of clinging to the Dhamma does not mean ceasing to distinguish the wholesome from the unwholesome. According to [AN 9.7](#), intentional killing, theft, sexual intercourse, and lying are impossible for an arahant monk.

In practice, this scheme should be used not to claim stages for oneself or assign them to others, but to check the direction: are identity views, doubt, clinging, sensual craving, ill will, conceit, and ignorance becoming weaker? The criteria are qualitative. Another person’s stage cannot be determined infallibly from outward signs, isolated experiences, or declarations. Such an assessment requires the corresponding direct knowledge possessed by the Buddha and some arahants. Statements such as “I am definitely a *sotāpanna*” are not a reliable criterion of attainment and may feed *māna* and *upādāna*, revealing clinging to views.

5. The Four Noble Truths: Tasks, Not Merely Propositions

The Four Noble Truths matter not only as facts, but as practical tasks. In the Pali version of [SN 56.11](#), the knowledge-and-vision of each truth unfolds in three rounds: knowledge of the truth, knowledge of the task appropriate to it, and knowledge that the task has been completed. Together these make twelve aspects.

Truth	What is to be recognized	Task
<i>dukkha ariyasacca</i>	Conditioned experience is unreliable and does not provide final satisfaction.	<i>pariññeyya</i> - to be fully understood.
<i>samudaya ariyasacca</i>	<i>Dukkha</i> arises from <i>taṇhā</i> : craving for sensuality, becoming, and non-becoming.	<i>pahātabba</i> - to be abandoned.
<i>nirodha ariyasacca</i>	With the cessation of <i>taṇhā</i> , <i>dukkha</i> ceases.	<i>sacchikātabba</i> - to be realized.
<i>magga ariyasacca</i>	There is a path of practice leading to cessation.	<i>bhāvetabba</i> - to be developed and brought to realization.

Three Kinds of *dukkha*

It is useful to distinguish three aspects of *dukkha*.

- ***Dukkha-dukkhatā*** - evident painfulness: bodily pain, mental pain, grief, sorrow, dejection, and despair.

- **Vipariṇāma-dukkhatā** - the unsatisfactoriness of change. Even a pleasant feeling is not a reliable support: it changes, disappears, and, when clung to, becomes a cause of suffering.
- **Saṅkhāra-dukkhatā** - the unreliability of all that is conditioned. Everything composite depends on conditions, is not under full control, and is subject to change and dissolution; it therefore cannot be a final refuge.

Dukkha is not limited to pain. Pain is its coarsest layer. Deeper lie the unsatisfactoriness of change and the very unreliability of conditioned processes.

A practical formula:

- *dukkha* is to be seen so clearly that one stops seeking a final refuge in anything conditioned;
- *taṇhā* is to be recognized as it arises, rather than noticed only in retrospect;
- *nirodha* is to be tested as the actual cessation of craving and clinging;
- *magga* is to be developed through body, speech, livelihood, attention, and collectedness.

6. *Magga*: the Path as an Integrated Training

The path is not reducible to meditation, philosophy, reading suttas, or special experiences. It is integrated: view shapes intention; intention purifies speech and action; ethics supports freedom from remorse; freedom from remorse facilitates joy, tranquility, and collectedness; and a collected mind becomes fit for knowledge-and-vision. This is well reflected in [AN 11.2](#): wholesome qualities do not operate as isolated components, but support one another as a chain of conditions.

[Dhp 19–20](#) emphasizes that it is better to know a little and live in accordance with the Dhamma than to know many texts without putting them into practice.

It is useful to review *sīla* regularly: speech, actions, livelihood, and one’s observance of the precepts. Such review is needed not to generate guilt, but to recognize mistakes clearly, adjust conditions, and refine the practice.

The word *sammā* in the Eightfold Path is usually translated as “right.” Here it is not a badge of group membership or a moral label. “Right” means what leads to the cessation of *dukkha*, weakens *lobha*, *dosa*, and *moha*, does not sustain clinging to “I,” and accords with the Four Noble Truths.

The path is called eightfold for a reason: all eight factors support one another. Omitting one factor, or substituting something else for it, compromises the integrity and effectiveness of the training.

The column “Common Distortions” lists only a few typical errors, not every possible deviation. Standard definitions of the eight path factors are given in [SN 45.8](#).

Further examples of wrong directions can be found in the suttas: [DN 1](#) examines numerous speculative views; [MN 19](#) distinguishes intentions of sensuality, ill will, and harmfulness from their wholesome opposites; [MN 41](#) lists unwholesome forms of conduct by body, speech, and mind; [MN 117](#) contrasts wrong and right view, intention, speech, action, and livelihood; and [AN 5.177](#) names five kinds of trade a lay follower should avoid.

[DN 1](#) also shows the conditioned nature of views. Memory, reasoning, and meditative experiences themselves arise from conditions. If contact, feeling, craving, and clinging are not recognized, such experience easily becomes a basis for views about the self and the world.

The Eight Factors of the Path

Factor	What <i>sammā</i> means	Common distortions
<i>sammā-diṭṭhi</i> - right view	Seeing <i>dukkha</i> , its arising, its cessation, and the path; understanding <i>kamma</i> , <i>paṭiccasamuppāda</i> , impermanence, and the impersonal nature of the <i>khandhā</i> .	A view of an eternal self, an observing soul, or pure consciousness as an essence; the nihilistic claim “there is no one, so nothing matters”; clinging to an opinion as proof that “I am right.”
<i>sammā-saṅkappa</i> - right intention	The intention of renunciation, non-ill-will, and harmlessness; directing the mind toward relinquishment rather than acquisition.	Plans for sensual gratification, revenge, self-assertion, or the suppression of oneself or others; spiritual ambition.
<i>sammā-vācā</i> - right speech	Abstaining from false, divisive, harsh, and idle speech; speech that is timely, truthful, beneficial, and does not nourish <i>dosa</i> .	Sarcasm, gossip, pressure, argument for the sake of self-assertion, “truth” used as a weapon, and spiritual labels used to demean.
<i>sammā-kammanta</i> - right action	Bodily actions that do not harm: abstaining from killing, stealing, and sexual misconduct; within a broader ethical foundation, also abstaining from intoxicants; care for living beings.	Harm justified by utility, goals, practice, or emotion; indulgence of impulses; ascetic violence toward the body.
<i>sammā-ājīva</i> - right livelihood	A way of earning a living that is not built on harm, deceit, exploitation, or the intensification of defilements.	Income obtained through violence or deception, by exploiting people’s dependence, or by manipulating fear, craving, or spiritual authority.
<i>sammā-vāyāma</i> - right effort	The four efforts: preventing unwholesome states from arising, abandoning arisen unwholesome states, developing wholesome states, and maintaining arisen wholesome states.	Laziness and distraction, but also violence toward oneself, suppressing desires without understanding, and harsh, joyless overexertion.
<i>sammā-sati</i> - right mindfulness/recollection	Mindfulness of body, feeling, mind, and <i>dhammā</i> as processes that arise and cease; <i>satipaṭṭhāna</i> .	A dissociated observer, a mechanical “came and went,” or retreat into vague awareness without distinguishing <i>taṇhā</i> and <i>upādāna</i> .

Factor	What <i>sammā</i> means	Common distortions
<i>sammā-samādhī</i> - right collectedness	Collectedness free from the hindrances and supportive of wisdom; in the standard formula, the four <i>jhānas</i> .	Chasing states, dependence on calm, pride in attainments, and mistaking trance or blankness for liberation.

The Noble Path may unfold differently for different practitioners. In [AN 4.162](#), both painful and pleasant practice are distinguished, and either may lead to slow or swift realization.

It is not enough merely to feel that one is moving forward: in a forest, one may be certain one is walking toward the way out while still going in circles. Moreover, as long as the mind remains defiled, a person is not always able to assess their own position correctly. The direction of practice therefore cannot be checked by a single inner impression. One must compare one's practice with the Buddha's instructions, observe its effects in behavior and the state of mind, and, when necessary, seek guidance from experienced and trustworthy practitioners. What matters is lasting change over time: are craving, hostility, and ignorance weakening, and are the factors of the path developing?

Neither the difficulty nor the ease of practice, by itself, shows whether the direction has been chosen correctly or how quickly liberation will be attained.

Right Intention Before an Action

Right intention (*sammā-saṅkappa*) directs the mind toward renunciation, goodwill, and harmlessness. It does not guarantee that craving, hostility, or fear will disappear immediately. The task is to establish a direction in advance to which one can return when the mind begins to lose clarity.

Before a difficult situation, it is useful to pause briefly and recollect:

May my mind not change for the worse. I will not utter harmful words. I will wish this person well, maintaining goodwill and not nourishing inward hatred. Beginning with this person, I will extend goodwill to the whole world: vast, measureless, free from hostility and ill will.

This formula is based on [MN 21](#), where a practitioner resolves not to let the mind become corrupted, not to speak bad words, to maintain compassion, and not to nourish inward hatred.

An intention is not a promise that all subsequent events will be fully under control. Another person may behave harshly, the situation may prove more difficult than expected, and mindfulness may be lost. Practice consists in noticing the direction of the mind again and returning to the intention.

In [MN 61](#), an action is to be examined three times: before it, during it, and after it. Before acting, one may ask:

- Will this lead to harm for me?
- Will this lead to harm for another?
- Will this lead to harm for both of us?

The same question is asked during the action. Afterward, the actual consequences are assessed. If actions of body, speech, or mind have caused harm, this is to be acknowledged, examined, and not repeated.

In [MN 19](#), thoughts are divided into two directions: sensuality, ill will, and harmfulness on one side; renunciation, goodwill, and harmlessness on the other. What the mind frequently returns to gradually becomes its habitual inclination. Right intention must therefore not only be understood, but restored again and again.

The test is whether speech and action are changing, and how they affect the mind.

***Sammā-vāyāma*: Right Effort in More Detail**

Sammā-vāyāma is not a tense struggle against oneself, but the wise shaping of conditions. The classical formula is: prevent unwholesome states from arising, abandon unwholesome states that have arisen, develop wholesome states that have not yet arisen, and maintain wholesome states that have arisen.

In [SN 4.4](#), the path is compressed into two conditions: directing attention wisely and applying effort rightly. This does not replace the Eightfold Path, but reveals its heart.

[MN 2](#) shows that the taints (*āsavā*) are abandoned in different ways: by seeing, restraining, using wisely, enduring, avoiding, removing, and developing. This is an important clue: not every problem should be addressed with the same technique. Sometimes an erroneous view must be seen; sometimes the senses restrained; sometimes an unpleasant feeling endured; sometimes a harmful situation avoided; sometimes an unwholesome thought removed; and sometimes factors of the path developed.

[MN 20](#) gives a practical sequence for working with unwholesome thoughts. If the mind is seized by sensual desire, ill will, or cruelty, one may direct attention to another wholesome object; see the danger and cost of the thought; stop feeding it with attention; examine how it is constructed and calm its formation; and, if the mind remains strongly seized, restrain it firmly. It is better to begin with the gentler methods. Harsher restraint is appropriate as a last resort.

The practical test of right effort is simple: afterward there should be less *lobha*, *dosa*, and *moha*, less inward violence, and more clarity. If effort makes the mind proud, constricted, angry, or dry, the approach should be reconsidered.

The Three Trainings

1. *sīla* - ethics. It reduces the coarse *dukkha* created through body and speech.
2. *samādhi* - collectedness. It weakens the hindrances and makes the mind fit for seeing subtle processes.
3. *paññā* - wisdom. It sees *anicca*, *dukkha*, *anattā*, and *paṭiccasamuppāda*, and ends clinging.

A Brief Path Check

Before acting, one may ask:

- Does this strengthen *lobha*, *dosa*, and *moha*, or weaken them?
- Does this make the mind clearer or more clouded?
- Does this create a story about “I” and “mine,” or release it?
- Does this lead toward simplicity or needless complication?

7. The Five Precepts: *sīla* as Training in Wisdom

The five precepts (*pañca-sīla*) are better understood not as external commandments or reasons for guilt, but as training rules (*sikkhāpada*). They help reveal which actions of body,

speech, and mind lead to less harm, greater clarity, and freedom from remorse, and which nourish *lobha*, *dosa*, and *moha*.

In this sense, *sīla* is not separate from wisdom. Ethical conduct cultivates the ability to distinguish the wholesome from the unwholesome. One may know a great deal and still fail to see harm, falsehood, appropriation, violence, and carelessness. In the Dhamma, wisdom is tested not only by knowledge, but also by one's actions.

Precept	Practical meaning	Quality disclosed
<i>Pāṇātipātā veramaṇī sikkhāpadaṃ samādiyāmi</i>	Abstaining from killing and intentionally causing harm.	<i>ahiṃsā, mettā</i>
<i>Adinnādānā veramaṇī sikkhāpadaṃ samādiyāmi</i>	Not taking what has not been given voluntarily.	<i>santutṭhi</i>
<i>Kāmesu micchācārā veramaṇī sikkhāpadaṃ samādiyāmi</i>	Not causing harm through sensual and sexual conduct.	<i>brahmacariya, anurakkhā</i>
<i>Musāvādā veramaṇī sikkhāpadaṃ samādiyāmi</i>	Abstaining from falsehood and harmful speech.	<i>sacca</i>
<i>Surā-meraya-majja-pamāda-tṭhānā veramaṇī sikkhāpadaṃ samādiyāmi</i>	Abstaining from intoxicating substances and causes of heedlessness.	<i>appamāda</i>

Not a Commandment, but a Training Rule

A *sikkhāpada* is a rule of training. It does not say, “be perfect right now.” It indicates a direction: train conduct of body, speech, and mind that reduces harm and supports the path.

When a precept has been broken, practice does not consist in self-condemnation. It is more useful to see honestly: what condition was present, what intention stood behind the action, what the consequences were, how it affected the mind, what can be repaired, and how recurrence can be prevented.

What to Support and What to Avoid

In DN 21, the Buddha examines three areas of practice:

- bodily conduct - *kāyasamācāra*;
- verbal conduct - *vacīsamācāra*;
- seeking and striving - *pariyesanā*.

The criterion is the same in each case. What, when sustained, causes unwholesome qualities to increase and wholesome qualities to decrease should not be sustained. What, when sustained, causes unwholesome qualities to decrease and wholesome qualities to increase should be sustained.

Hiri and *ottappa*: Refraining from the Unwholesome

Hiri is moral conscience, through which an unwholesome act is seen as unworthy and incompatible with the training. *Ottappa* is caution regarding the harm that such an act may cause oneself and others. These qualities are needed to notice a dangerous direction before it becomes speech or action. In [AN 7.65](#), they are named as conditions for guarding the senses, ethical conduct, and the path.

Joy Grounded in Freedom from Remorse

The suttas say of the Dhamma that it is good in the beginning, good in the middle, and good in the end.

When precepts are kept not out of fear or guilt, and not for the image of “I am a good person,” they support freedom from remorse. Joy may gradually arise from this: the mind sees fewer defilements, less falsehood, less harshness, and less heedlessness.

The path leads to a reduction of *dukkha*, although as practice develops it may seem that there is more *dukkha*: the mind begins to notice defilements, craving, and habitual patterns that previously remained in the background. Yet the overall trend of healthy practice is less craving and *dukkha*, and greater clarity.

1. Not Causing Harm: *ahiṃsā* and *mettā*

The canonical formula of the first precept concerns intentionally depriving a living being of life. Refraining from cruelty in speech, thought, and one’s attitude toward oneself is a broader practical development of *adosa* and *mettā*; however, not every arising of anger or a harsh thought is technically a breach of the first precept.

The first precept concerns more than physical killing. Its broader meaning is not to make violence an instrument for solving problems. Violence may be expressed through body, speech, thought, one’s treatment of others, and one’s treatment of oneself.

A middle way is needed here between indulgence and self-aggression. Indulgence says, “because I want it, I may do it.” Self-aggression says, “I am bad; I must break myself.” The impulse should be seen and not fed, without hatred of oneself.

Ahiṃsā is nonviolence, including the refusal to cultivate violence in thought. *Mettā* adds a positive dimension: not merely “do no harm,” but wish for safety, freedom from hostility, and the lessening of suffering.

2. Not Taking What Is Not Given: *santuṭṭhi*

The second precept is not limited to obvious theft. It concerns everything the mind wants to appropriate without explicit permission: objects, money, time, attention, another person’s labor, ideas, credit, or trust.

A subtler violation begins with the thought: “this is not mine, but it ought to be mine.” Here *lobha* and the construction of “mine” can be seen. *Santuṭṭhi* is contentment, non-acquisitiveness, and freedom from appropriation.

A separate and subtle subject is the “theft of Dhamma”: using the language, ideas, or authority of the Dhamma for status, influence, gain, or a self-image. The issue here is not copyright, but using what is sacred to feed *māna* and *bhava*.

3. Sensual and Sexual Conduct: *brahmacariya* and *anurakkhā*

For a layperson, the third precept usually means abstaining from sexual conduct that causes harm: infidelity, deception, coercion, exploitation, betrayal, using another person merely as an object for one’s own pleasure, or taking advantage of weakness or lack of awareness.

In the strict sense, *brahmacariya* means celibacy or abstinence. On the monastic path, this is complete abstention from sexual conduct. For a layperson, honesty, fidelity, care, respect for boundaries, and harmlessness are important. It is therefore useful to place alongside it the word *anurakkhā*: care, protection of trust, and attentiveness in relationships.

4. Speech: *sacca*

The fourth precept is usually formulated as abstaining from falsehood, but it is useful to view speech more broadly: false speech, divisive speech, harsh speech, and idle chatter.

Falsehood is dangerous not only because it may harm someone. It damages wisdom by separating the mind from reality. Lying to others often begins with lying to oneself: excuses, rationalization, emotional reasoning, “it was not my fault,” “I was forced,” or “it was for the greater good.”

Sacca is truthfulness. But truthfulness is not a license for harshness. Speech is examined not only for factual accuracy, but also for intention, timeliness, benefit, and harmlessness.

5. Sobriety: *appamāda*

The canonical formula names *surā*, *meraya*, and *majja* as a basis for *pamāda*. Applying this principle to modern drugs, psychedelics, and microdosing is an expanded practical interpretation.

The fifth precept concerns intoxicating substances and everything that becomes a basis for *pamāda*: heedlessness, distraction, and loss of vigilance. The classical formula refers primarily to substances: *surā*, *meraya*, and *majja*. In practical terms, this includes alcohol, drugs, psychedelics, and other psychoactive substances capable of causing intoxication, stupefaction, loss of control, or a noticeable impairment of clarity.

An important criterion is this: if a substance, at a plausible dose, is capable of causing intoxication or stupefaction, it falls within the scope of this precept. “Microdosing” therefore does not make a substance permissible: the precept concerns not only whether strong intoxication has occurred on a particular occasion, but also the intentional use of a substance that is a basis for *pamāda*. At small doses, intoxication may go unnoticed.

A complete breach can usually be analyzed as follows:

1. an intoxicating substance is present;
2. the person knows or understands what it is;
3. there is an intention to consume it;
4. an action is performed in order to consume it;
5. the substance enters the body;
6. there is no extreme medical necessity in which no reasonable alternative is available.

The medical exception concerns situations in which the substance is used as medicine, no better alternative is available, and refusal could cause serious harm. It is not a justification for seeking experiences, spiritual states, relaxation, or experiments with consciousness.

The point is to maintain clarity. When the mind is clouded, it becomes easier to lie, cause harm, take what is not given, or yield to sensual desire. It also obstructs meditation: *sati* becomes weaker, *samādhi* coarser, and *paññā* is more easily replaced by impressions. Unusual states or insights may sometimes occur under the influence of substances, but they are likely to be chaotic, overvalued, and not conducive to liberation.

Appamāda is sobriety, conscientiousness, attentiveness, and care. This quality guards the entire practice.

Fact and Narrative

The precepts help distinguish a fact from the story by which the mind justifies an action.

- Fact: “I said something untrue.” Narrative: “I had no choice; I was forced.”
- Fact: “I took what was not given to me.” Narrative: “They already have plenty.”

- Fact: “I spoke harshly.” Narrative: “At least I was honest.”
- Fact: “I sought pleasure without considering the consequences.” Narrative: “I felt bad” or “That was how I felt.”

In this way, *sīla* becomes a practice of wise seeing: *avijjā* is already shaping a script, while *taṇhā* searches for an attractive justification.

The Precepts and Dependent Origination

A breach of a precept rarely begins with the action itself. The chain is usually visible earlier:

phassa → *vedanā* → *taṇhā* → *upādāna* → *bhava* → *jāti*.

Protecting Lay Life

In [DN 31](#), advice to a layperson is not limited to the five precepts. The sutta lists six harmful habits: intoxication, roaming at inappropriate times, absorption in entertainments, gambling, unwholesome companionship, and laziness.

The sutta suggests looking not at the label “good person” or “bad person,” but at the direction of a relationship. A false friend takes, flatters, makes empty promises, or accompanies one in wastefulness. A true friend helps, does not abandon one in trouble, restrains one from the unwholesome, encourages the wholesome, and shows compassion.

A Short Daily Review

At the end of the day, one may ask:

1. Where was there less harm today?
2. Where did I take what was not given?
3. Where did sensual desire begin to govern attention?
4. Where did speech distort reality?
5. Where was there heedlessness or loss of clarity?
6. Which root manifested: *lobha*, *dosa*, or *moha*?
7. Which quality should be strengthened tomorrow: *mettā*, *santuṭṭhi*, *anurakkhā*, *sacca*, or *appamāda*?

8. The Five *khandhā* and the Three Characteristics

The five *khandhā* are not “components of a real self,” but groups of processes to which the mind habitually clings as “I” and “mine.”

<i>Khandha</i>	What it includes	How the mind clings
<i>rūpa</i>	body, material form, elements	“my body,” “I am beautiful,” “I am ill,” “I must control the body”
<i>vedanā</i>	pleasant, unpleasant, and neutral tone	“I feel good,” “I feel bad,” “I want this feeling”

<i>Khandha</i>	What it includes	How the mind clings
<i>saññā</i>	perception and recognition: in a coarse form, distinguishing, recognizing, and identifying an object; in a subtle form (<i>sukhuma-saññā</i>), the very definiteness of what is perceived, even before awareness and recognition	coarse: distinguishing a color, recognizing features; subtle: perceiving the character of what is present without identifying it
<i>saṅkhārā</i>	intentions and impulses involved in shaping experience and action	“I decided,” “this is what I am like,” “this is my character”
<i>viññāṇa</i>	consciousness, awareness of an object	“I am aware,” “I am the observer,” “I am pure consciousness”

In [MN 43](#), feeling, perception, and consciousness are said to be conjoined rather than separate. The five *khandhā* matter because they encompass the field of ordinary experience. Everything ordinarily taken as “I” or “mine” is found here: body, feeling, perception, formations, or consciousness.

The formula “this is not mine, I am not this, this is not my *attā*” does not mean that another “I” is hidden beyond the five aggregates. In [MN 109](#), a monk falls into precisely this confusion: if the five aggregates are “not self,” then what “self” will be affected by actions performed by what is “not self”? The Buddha calls him *moghapurisa*, a fool who is ignorant and under the sway of craving. In [SN 35.23](#), “the all” is described through the six sense fields and their objects; one who asserts some other “all” would be unable to give a coherent account if questioned about it. The search for an “I” beyond experience is conditioned by *bhava-taṇhā*.

Conventional designations such as “man,” “woman,” “parent,” or “teacher” are not in themselves the problem. Clinging arises when a designation is appropriated as “I” or becomes a basis for comparison. In [SN 5.2](#), Somā rejects the idea that being a woman obstructs liberation.

Why the Five *khandhā* Are Needed When There Is *paṭiccasamuppāda*

The five *khandhā* and *paṭiccasamuppāda* answer different questions. *Paṭiccasamuppāda* shows how *dukkha* arises and ceases through conditions. The five aggregates show what the mind takes as “I” and “mine”: body, feeling, perception, formative activities, and consciousness.

The *khandhā* are therefore especially important for seeing *anattā*. They are not five parts that make up a real subject, but five processes that, under *upādāna*, become a field of appropriation. The chain shows how suffering is constructed; the aggregates show the material from which the sense of “me” is constructed.

The five *khandhā* and the twelve sense fields describe the same experience from different angles. The *āyatana* show through which door contact occurs: the eye and the visible, the ear and sound, all the way to mind and *dhammā*. The *khandhā* show the composition of the experience that has arisen: *rūpa*, *vedanā*, *saññā*, *saṅkhārā*, and *viññāṇa*.

For example, when an apple is seen, the eye and visible form belong to *rūpa*; the arising visual consciousness, to *viññāṇa*; the pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral tone, to *vedanā*; recognition of “an apple,” to *saññā*; and the intention to take it, eat it, or walk past, to *saṅkhārā*.

These are two different ways of describing the same event: in the system of *āyatana*, it is examined through the six internal and six external sense fields; in the system of *khandhā*, through the five aggregates.

The three characteristics, *anicca*, *dukkha*, and *anattā*, should not be turned into verbal formulas. They are to become a way of seeing.

- *anicca*: what has arisen changes, cannot be held, and disintegrates.
- *dukkha*: what changes and is not subject to control cannot be a final support.
- *anattā*: there is no independent, permanent, governing, controlling self in this.

Anicca, *dukkha*, and *anattā* reveal themselves differently under different conditions, which makes them more difficult to see.

Anattā should not be turned into the statement “I do not exist.” Nor should it be confused with depersonalization or derealization, which may involve detachment, emotional numbness, a sense of observing oneself from outside, or a sense that events are unreal. Such states are not in themselves wisdom and are not criteria of liberation.

The practical meaning of *anattā* is to see conditioned processes without appropriation: “this is not mine, this I am not, this is not my essence.” The criterion is not how unusual an experience feels, but the weakening of *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, hostility, and conceit. If a sense of unreality becomes persistent, frightening, or disruptive to ordinary life, professional help is needed rather than an attempt to deepen the state through meditation.

9. *Paṭiccasamuppāda*: the Mechanism of *dukkha*

Paṭiccasamuppāda is dependent origination: when conditions are present, a result arises; with the cessation of the conditions, the corresponding result ceases. It is neither merely a theory of rebirth nor merely a psychology of the present moment, but a way of seeing how *dukkha* is constructed when *avijjā*, *taṇhā*, and *upādāna*.

In practice, *paṭiccasamuppāda* is needed not as a philosophical map of the world, but to see where the chain is being fed and where that support can be withdrawn.

Conditions of *dukkha*

Paṭiccasamuppāda does not simply mean that “everything is connected to everything,” nor does it describe a first cause of the world. The standard formula identifies specific conditions through which *dukkha* arises and continues, and shows the cessation of the process when those conditions cease.

Beginning the sequence with *avijjā* does not make ignorance first in time. [AN 10.61](#) says that no beginning of it can be discerned, but the conditions that nourish it can be recognized.

Samāsāra is not only a cycle of birth and death. It is the entire mechanism of the twelve links: *avijjā*, *saṅkhārā*, *viññāṇa*, *nāma-rūpa*, the six sense fields, contact, feeling, craving, clinging, becoming, birth, and aging-and-death. Death does not liberate by itself: if *avijjā*, *taṇhā*, and *upādāna* remain, the dissolution of one form becomes part of further becoming.

The standard chain:

1. *avijjā* - ignorance.
2. *saṅkhārā* - formative activities.

3. *viññāṇa* - consciousness.
4. *nāma-rūpa* - name-and-form.
5. *saḷāyatana* - the six sense fields.
6. *phassa* - contact.
7. *vedanā* - feeling.
8. *taṇhā* - craving.
9. *upādāna* - clinging.
10. *bhava* - becoming; sensual, form, and formless becoming are distinguished.
11. *jāti* - birth: the appearance of a being, the arising of the aggregates, and the acquisition of sense fields.
12. *jarāmaraṇa* - aging-and-death, together with sorrow, pain, dejection, and despair.

$avijjā \rightarrow saṅkhārā \rightarrow viññāṇa \rightleftarrows nāma-rūpa \rightarrow saḷāyatana \rightarrow phassa$
 $\rightarrow vedanā \rightarrow taṇhā \rightarrow upādāna \rightarrow bhava \rightarrow jāti \rightarrow jarāmaraṇa$

$āsava \rightleftarrows avijjā$

Mutual Conditionality Within the Chain

The twelve-link chain shows how some processes condition others. At the same time, some links condition one another.

In [DN 15](#) and [SN 12.67](#), *viññāṇa* and *nāma-rūpa* are presented as mutually conditioning processes. In [SN 12.67](#), they are compared to two sheaves of reeds that stand by supporting one another:

$viññāṇa \rightleftarrows nāma-rūpa.$

In [MN 9](#), the mutual conditionality of the *āsava* and ignorance is shown in a similar way:

$āsava \rightleftarrows avijjā$

There are three kinds of *āsava*: the influx of sensuality (*kāmāsava*), the influx of becoming (*bhavāsava*), and the influx of ignorance (*avijjāsava*).

In experience, the *āsava* do not necessarily arise separately and may color the body, feelings, perception, and mind all at once. The influx of sensuality (*kāmāsava*) draws the mind toward what is sensually pleasant and toward continuing or repeating a pleasant experience. The influx of becoming (*bhavāsava*) assembles a particular “I” and the role that goes with it: “I am like this,” “this is happening to me.” A particular attitude toward what is happening and corresponding behavior then follow.

With the influx of ignorance (*avijjāsava*), clarity may drop sharply: processes cease to be recognized, and understanding that was previously available seems to disappear. This may encompass the whole of experience: “I understand nothing,” “I am just an ordinary person,” “what Dhamma are you talking about?,” “there was never any wisdom,” “perhaps none of this practice is needed at all.” The clouding itself may then seem like one’s own sound conclusion.

The influxes can mix. For example, the influx of becoming may occur together with ignorance: a dense sense of “I am like this” arises at the same time as clear recognition of that very

process is lost. More important than arguing with the content of the thoughts and roles that have arisen is recognizing the influx itself as a conditioned process.

Upādāna should not be understood merely as stronger craving. In [SN 12.2](#), craving is analyzed through the six sense fields, while clinging is analyzed through four domains: sensuality, views, rules and observances, and doctrines of self.

In practice, *upādāna* can be recognized when the mind is already holding to a pleasure, opinion, rule, or idea of oneself as “mine.”

Wholesome *saṅkhārā* as Supports for the Path

Unwholesome *saṅkhārā* directly nourish *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, *bhava*, and *dukkha*. This does not mean that every formation is simply “bad.” There are wholesome intentions, wholesome deeds, ethical conduct, generosity, mindfulness, collectedness, and wise attention. They create conditions under which the mind becomes less coarse and reactive, experiences less remorse, and more readily sees things as they are.

Yet even the wholesome can become an object of appropriation: “I am good,” “I practice,” “I attained,” “I will accumulate merit,” or “this is my state.” Wholesome qualities should therefore be developed without clinging.

Viññāṇa, *nāma-rūpa*, and *phassa*

In [SN 12.2](#), *nāma* includes feeling, perception, intention, contact, and attention, while *rūpa* consists of the four elements and the material form dependent on them.

Viññāṇa, the Six Sense Fields, and Contact

In dependent origination, *viññāṇa* should not be considered in isolation, but as part of a complex of interdependent processes. In [SN 12.2](#), *viññāṇa* is analyzed into six classes of consciousness:

1. eye consciousness;
2. ear consciousness;
3. nose consciousness;
4. tongue consciousness;
5. body consciousness;
6. mind consciousness.

In concrete sensory experience, consciousness manifests through the corresponding sense field when an object is present. In [MN 148](#), for example, eye consciousness arises in dependence on the eye and visible form:

eye + visible form → eye consciousness.

The meeting of the eye, visible form, and eye consciousness is called *phassa*, or contact. The same principle applies to the other sense doors.

The chain shows which processes condition other processes, while the account of the six sense fields shows how consciousness manifests in a concrete sensory experience.

One Sensory Episode in Close-Up

Dependent origination can be investigated directly within a single arising process.

For example, when a word is heard:

ear + sound → ear consciousness → *phassa* → *vedanā*.

In [MN 18](#), the further unfolding of the process is shown through perception, thinking, and conceptual proliferation:

phassa → *vedanā* → *saññā* → *vitakka* → *papañca*.

The practical point is to recognize directly how a process arises through conditions, changes through conditions, and contains no “I.”

In [MN 38](#), the Buddha rejects the view that one and the same consciousness wanders through the round of rebirths. Consciousness arises dependently and is named after the condition on which it arises: with the eye and forms, visual consciousness; with the ear and sounds, auditory consciousness; with the mind and mental objects, mental consciousness.

Tajjo samannāhāro in MN 28

[MN 28](#) says that even when a sense faculty is unimpaired and an object has entered its range, the corresponding kind of consciousness does not manifest without *tajjo samannāhāro*. The phrase may be understood as “corresponding engagement” or “corresponding gathering.” In context, it is probably connected with the engagement or direction of attention in relation to the particular object.

Manasikāra is included in *nāma* in SN 12.2 and means directing attention. The exact relationship between *manasikāra* and *tajjo samannāhāro* is not explained in the suttas, so there are no grounds either for identifying them with one another or, conversely, for treating them as two distinct processes.

One may suppose that, in experience, this is connected with the operation of *saṅkhārā* as a kind of filter: some details stand out while others pass unnoticed. For practice, however, it is more important to see the overall conditionality of the process than to determine the exact mechanism of this selection.

Separately, one can observe in experience a moment when an object is perceived and contact occurs, but the process does not unfold further into *vedanā*: no pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral feeling arises, and the subsequent chain does not continue.

Two Scales of Reading

On the broader scale, *avijjā* and *saṅkhārā* sustain a stream that leads to new birth, aging, and death. This describes the continuation of *saṃsāra*.

In a practical analysis, the same direction can be noticed within an individual episode: contact conditions feeling; under ignorance, feeling becomes a support for craving, clinging, and a role such as “I am right,” “I am offended,” or “I must.” This role arises, changes, dissolves, and brings *dukkha*.

An arisen state is not yet the same as *bhava*. A bodily illness may remain simply a bodily illness, anxiety simply anxiety, irritation simply irritation. Becoming becomes especially

visible when an appropriated story is assembled and sustained around the state: “I am ill,” “I am anxious,” “I am offended,” “this is what I am like.”

The language of “becoming a role” and “the birth of an offended self” is a practical analogy. It helps reveal the direction of craving and clinging in present experience, but does not replace the primary meanings of *bhava* and *jāti*.

Fear of Death

Fear of death is connected not only with the bodily response to danger, but also with appropriating processes as “I” and “mine”: fear arises at the prospect of losing what is taken to be one’s own existence. When this appropriation ceases, a bodily response to threat may still arise through conditions, but it does not continue as fear for “me.”

Three Ways to Read the Chain

- **Direct reading:** shows how, in the presence of *avijjā*, one condition after another constructs *dukkha*.
- **Reverse diagnostic reading:** begins with already noticeable tension, resentment, fear, or dependence, and asks: what *bhava* is here? What is being clung to through *upādāna*? What *taṇhā* nourishes it? From what *vedanā* did it grow? What was the *phassa*?
- **Reading through cessation:** the chain is not broken by force. When a condition is recognized and not fed, the corresponding process loses its support. In a single episode, craving and clinging may cease; the complete cessation of *avijjā* is the ultimate horizon of the path.

A Liberating Chain of Conditions: from *dukkha* to *vimutti*

SN 12.23 presents not only a *samsāric* sequence but a liberating one. When *dukkha* is understood as the unreliability of the conditioned, it becomes an *upanisā*, a condition for turning toward the path.

Link	Practical meaning
<i>dukkha</i>	A sober recognition that conditioned experience is unreliable, not a reason for despair.
<i>saddhā</i>	Confidence: there is a path worth testing.
<i>pamojja, pīti</i>	Joy and energy arising from a wholesome direction.
<i>passaddhi, sukha</i>	Tranquility of body and mind, gentle stability.
<i>samādhi</i>	Collectedness capable of seeing subtle conditions.
<i>yathābhūtañāṇadassana</i>	Knowledge-and-vision of processes as conditioned, impermanent, unsatisfactory, and impersonal.
<i>nibbidā, virāga</i>	Disenchantment with former clinging and the fading of the coloring of experience by “I want” and “mine.”
<i>vimutti, āsavakkhayañāṇa</i>	Liberation and knowledge of the exhaustion of the <i>āsavā</i> .

In AN 11.2, the same logic is expressed through *sīla*: wholesome conduct leads to freedom from remorse (*avippaṭisāra*), then to joy, tranquility, *samādhi*, knowledge-and-vision, *nibbidā*, *virāga*, and *vimutti*. The path develops by cultivating supportive conditions, not by suppressing experience.

10. *Saṅkhārā* and *cetanā*: Where New *kamma* Arises

Saṅkhārā are formative activities. In dependent origination, arising conditioned by *avijjā*, they support the further unfolding of experience; the suttas distinguish bodily, verbal, and mental formations. As one of the five *khandhā*, the term points primarily to intentions (*cetanā*). In direct observation, their formative activity appears as impulses, tendencies, reactions, and habitual ways of responding to events. In both cases, these are conditioned formative activities, not a hidden storehouse of memories from past lives.

Kamma literally means action, but in the Dhamma it primarily means intentional action. In [AN 6.63](#), the Buddha says, “It is intention, bhikkhus, that I call *kamma*.” Having intended, one performs *kamma* through body, speech, and mind.

Kamma is not a general law of causation or a transferable “karmic force.” It is intentional action. Its ripening and result (*vipāka*) should be distinguished from the action itself.

The involuntary arising of a thought is not yet identical with an intentional mental action. In practice, it is important to recognize *cetanā*: does the mind begin to support, develop, use, or enact the arisen thought? *Kamma* can be performed through body, speech, and mind.

Phassa, or contact, is identified as a source of *kamma*. This matters for practice: intention does not appear as an independent entity. It arises within a stream of experience in which there are contact, feeling, perception, tendencies, and a state of mind. *Kamma* should therefore be seen not only after an act has been performed, but earlier, as contact begins to shape the direction of action.

The fruit of *kamma* should not be confused with all the consequences of a situation, which are produced by many conditions. An intentional action may bear fruit here and now, later in this life, or in subsequent lives. [SN 36.21](#) rejects the view that every feeling one experiences is caused solely by past *kamma*, while [MN 136](#) cautions against drawing straightforward conclusions from a single observable result.

The practical question is: what intention arose from contact, what action of body, speech, or mind follows from it, and does it lead to the weakening of greed, aversion, delusion, and clinging?

Action, Fruit, and Causal Continuity

[MN 135](#) says that beings inherit the consequences of their own actions. This should not be understood as a reference to a permanent owner, a soul, or a separate storehouse of *kamma*. The point is causality: intentional actions enter into a sequence of conditions and may bear fruit.

At the same time, no unchanging consciousness or entity passes from one birth to another. What continues is a causally conditioned process in which previous intentional actions, together with craving, clinging, and other conditions, influence subsequent arising.

In [SN 12.38](#), intention, planning, and persistent mental tendencies are shown as conditions that sustain further arising. *Cetanā* directs action and gives it kammic significance; when craving and clinging are present, such actions can sustain the continuation of becoming and birth.

How *saṅkhārā* Appear in Experience

In experience, *saṅkhārā* are often visible as an early inclination of the mind: an impulse to think, speak, act, hold on, push away, prove, hide, continue a storyline, or return to an object. This is not always coarse *taṇhā* or fully formed *upādāna*, but it is already a direction

of experience. The earlier the impulse is recognized, the less opportunity it has to solidify into speech, action, a role, and new *bhava*.

Until a *saṅkhārā* is noticed, the reaction unfolds automatically: the arising impulse is appropriated as “I want,” “I decided,” or “I need.” When it is recognized as a conditioned process, it becomes possible not to follow it.

Conflict Between *saṅkhārā*

Several *saṅkhārā* may arise simultaneously in one person, impelling different actions. Depending on conditions, one may become dominant while another recedes. In interaction, one person’s reaction may become a condition that strengthens or weakens another person’s *saṅkhārā*.

The *Bhava* of “We”

Bhava can also be built around “we”: “our team,” “we are like-minded,” or “we are better.” Around this “we,” boundaries, rules, and expectations form, while what lies outside begins to be perceived through the opposition of “us” and “them.”

At the same time, each participant has their own image of this “we,” and these images may differ.

A thought should not be reduced to *saṅkhārā* alone: consciousness, perception, feeling, attention, and intention participate in it. But a thought is conditioned by formative activities and may become a new *saṅkhārā* if the mind picks it up, turns it over repeatedly, elaborates it, and appropriates it. A useful question is not “why did the thought appear?” but “what impulse wants to continue it, use it, or turn it into ‘mine’?”

Thought and *papañca*

MN 18 shows how experience becomes a basis for mental proliferation. When a faculty, an object, and the corresponding consciousness are present, *phassa* arises. In the mental sense field, mind, a thought or image, and mental consciousness together constitute *mano-samphassa*. From contact, *vedanā* arises; what is felt is perceived; what is perceived, the mind begins to think about; and what is thought about, under ignorance, proliferates into *papañca*.

Saññā marks a feature of the object: “sound,” “face,” “word,” “danger,” “pleasant.” Attention may then begin picking out details, *anuvyañjana*: tone of voice, facial expression, implication, comparison, or a past memory. If this is not recognized, *papañca* arises: a story, an argument, an image of “me,” an image of “the other,” expectation, defense, resentment, or desire.

Papañca may begin not with a chain of thoughts, but with a small lapse in recognizing what is happening. When recollection weakens, an association or supposition that has arisen fills in the missing parts of experience. This construction then becomes a support for further conclusions, and the story begins to proliferate.

Papañca takes hold especially easily around “I” and “mine.” The constructions then do more than explain what is happening: they also defend an appropriated position, such as “my feelings,” “my thoughts,” or “how could they do this to me?”

An expansion of perception is not in itself *papañca*. More and more processes may be noticed without a story being built around them. *Papañca* begins when the mind picks up what is happening, interprets it, and unfolds a chain of further constructions.

A thought may be purely functional: remembering, speaking, going somewhere, preparing something, answering, or correcting an error. Under *avijjā*, however, a thought quickly becomes material for proliferation: “I think,” “this is my thought,” “I cannot be treated this way,” “I must prove this,” “I must hold on to this,” or “I must get rid of this.” The thought then ceases to be merely a mental event and becomes food for *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, and *bhava*.

The practical question is therefore not only “what thought arose?” but also: “how does the mind pick up this thought, what colors it, and where does proliferation around ‘I,’ ‘mine,’ and ‘for me’ begin?”

In DN 21, the further unfolding of this process is shown as follows:

papañcasaññāsaṅkhā → *vitakka* → *chanda*
→ *piyāppiya* → *issā-macchariya*
→ enmity, violence, rivalry, and malice.

Here *papañcasaññāsaṅkhā* means conceptual categories and designations arising from the proliferation of perception; *vitakka*, the direction of thought; *chanda*, desire or inclination toward something; *piyāppiya*, the division into what is “liked” and “disliked”; and *issā-macchariya*, envy and possessive stinginess.

Chanda is interest, desire, or intention to act. It can be wholesome when directed toward *sīla*, *sati*, *samādhi*, and *paññā*, and unwholesome when mixed with craving, self-assertion, or escape. Unlike wholesome *chanda*, *taṇhā* is craving for sensual pleasure, becoming, or non-becoming and serves as a condition for clinging.

A check for *saṅkhārā*: what does the mind want to do? Where is attention being drawn? What does the mind want to obtain from this thought, feeling, or situation? Are craving, fear, defense of a self-image, or control present? What conditions this, and where does “mine” arise?

The cessation of the chain does not mean the disappearance of all activities of the aggregates: the body walks, speech occurs, thoughts arise, and perception functions. But if these processes are not appropriated as “I,” they do not nourish *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, and *bhava*; old conditioning is exhausted, while no new chain of suffering is built.

Taṇhā can be recognized as an impulse: “I want,” “I do not want,” “may this continue,” “may this disappear.” With *upādāna*, the grasp becomes denser: the process is held, appropriated, or defended. *Papañca* may proliferate around this, while sustained appropriation develops into *bhava*.

Two Short Examples

Criticism. An unpleasant *vedanā* may meet old *saṅkhārā*: to defend, justify, attack, fall silent. If *cetanā* is not recognized, it passes into speech, action, or an ongoing inner drama and strengthens the role “I, the offended one” or “I, the one who is right.”

Praise. A pleasant *vedanā* may meet a tendency to seek approval: “may they see me this way again.” Praise then becomes food for the image “I am valuable,” rather than simply a pleasant contact that arose and ended.

11. How *dukkha* Is Constructed from the Unpleasant

An unpleasant *vedanā* is not yet the whole of *dukkha*. Suffering is constructed when feeling becomes a condition for *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, and *bhava*.

Example: a Harsh Comment

Even before the comment, *avijjā* may already be operating: a readiness to perceive experience through “me,” the need to be right, and “my worth.” The words therefore meet pre-existing tendencies.

Link	What it looks like
<i>avijjā, saṅkhārā</i>	Experience is already inclined to become personal; there are patterns of defending, attacking, justifying, and taking offense.
<i>viññāṇa, nāma-rūpa, saḷāyatana, phassa</i>	The words are heard or read, the mind recognizes their meaning, psychophysical experience takes shape, and contact occurs.
<i>vedanā</i>	An unpleasant tone: a sting, heat, fear, irritation.
<i>taṇhā</i>	“I want to remove this,” “I want to prove it,” “I want to reassert that I am right.”
<i>upādāna, bhava</i>	Clinging to an image and becoming a role: the defender, the offended one, the judge, the victim.
<i>jāti, jarāmaraṇa</i>	The “I who was insulted” is born; the role ages through replaying, exhaustion, guilt, or conflict.

Practice does not turn the unpleasant into the pleasant. It recognizes: “an unpleasant feeling arose through conditions; it does not have to become my story.”

12. How *dukkha* Is Constructed from the Pleasant and the Neutral

A pleasant feeling is not in itself unwholesome. Under *avijjā*, however, it easily becomes a support for “I” and “mine.”

The Pleasant: Praise

Phassa: words of praise are heard, or an approving message arrives. *Vedanā*: warmth, joy, lightness. *Taṇhā*: “I want more,” “may they see me this way.” *Upādāna*: “this proves that I am valuable.” *Bhava* and *jāti*: a “successful self,” a “loved self,” or a “practitioner self” is born. When the praise ends, the image has to be maintained, and anxiety, comparison, or fear of loss arises.

A wise response is to know the contact, the pleasant *vedanā*, and the possible craving without turning a pleasant experience into a personal biography. A pleasant feeling can simply be pleasant without being turned into “mine,” “let it remain,” or “I must hold on to this.” It is important to see when it becomes food for *taṇhā*.

Neutral *vedanā*: a Hidden Support for *avijjā*

Neutral *vedanā* is not the absence of feeling, but the tone arising from contact that is experienced as neither clearly pleasant nor clearly unpleasant. [MN 148](#) says that the pleasant can nourish the underlying tendency (*anusaya*) to passion, the unpleasant the underlying tendency to aversion, and the neutral, when its arising, cessation, gratification, danger, and conditioned nature are not understood, the underlying tendency to ignorance.

Vedanā itself is not yet craving, aversion, or ignorance. But if the feeling is not clearly understood, the corresponding underlying tendency may manifest: passion toward the pleasant, aversion toward the unpleasant, or ignorance regarding the neutral.

It is therefore important to notice the background of experience: clothing touching the skin, the pressure of the body on a chair, body temperature, the sensation of satiety, sounds from the street, thoughts, plans, and so forth. Pay particular attention to *mano-samphassa*: a thought is also an object of contact and produces *vedanā*. The neutral may provoke either a search for stimulation (“this is boring; I need to turn something on”) or fixation (“I will remain in this even state”). In both cases, *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, and *bhava* can be observed.

Neutral *vedanā* should not be confused with *upekkhā*: neutral feeling can be a dull background, whereas *upekkhā* as a factor of the path is clear, sober, and does not obstruct right action.

Checking the Pleasant and the Neutral

What was the *phassa*? What *vedanā* arose? Is there “I want more,” “I want to remove this,” or “I want to fill the background”? What image is being held through *upādāna*? What mode of *bhava* is taking shape? What will the dissolution of this state be like?

13. Where the Chain Can Be Interrupted

It is not necessary to catch the very first moment of *avijjā*. The chain can be weakened at different points. It is not broken by force. More precisely, when conditions are recognized and no longer fed, the process loses its support and gradually ceases. Practice consists not in suppression, but in clearly seeing exactly where *taṇhā* receives nourishment.

Where it was noticed	What can be done
At <i>phassa</i>	Slow down: “there was contact.” Do not add a story immediately.
At <i>vedanā</i>	Name the tone: pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral. Feel the body.
At <i>taṇhā</i>	See the promise: “if I get/remove this, things will be good.”
At <i>upādāna</i>	Find what the mind is holding to: being right, an image, safety, recognition, control.
At <i>bhava</i>	Recognize the role: the offended one, defender, winner, victim, controller, practitioner.
After <i>jāti</i>	Acknowledge: “the role has already been born.” Do not feed it through speech, action, and repetition.
At <i>jarāmarāṇa</i>	See the cost: exhaustion, guilt, anxiety, dependence, replaying.

Even if *taṇhā* has already arisen, this is not a failure. Even if *upādāna* has begun, this is not the end of practice. What matters more than catching it perfectly early is ending further nourishment.

14. Desire: Do Not Indulge or Suppress It, but Understand It

Desire does not have to be automatically fulfilled. But it should not be crushed either. Suppression often creates an inner dam: prohibition on the surface, accumulated tension underneath. Sooner or later, it bursts.

Three modes:

1. **Indulgence.** A desire arises and is immediately fulfilled. The mind learns that every *vedanā* must be prolonged or removed.
2. **Suppression.** A desire arises and is squeezed, condemned, forbidden. The desire is not understood, but driven underground and into shadow.
3. **Not feeding *taṇhā*.** Desire is seen as a process: bodily impulse, image, promise, thought, tension. It can be lived through without automatic fulfillment and without inner conflict.

The struggle against craving easily becomes another form of craving: craving for control, craving to conquer oneself, or craving for non-existence. It is therefore more useful to see the conditions of desire, its flavor, its cost, and the point where it is nourished.

Three Kinds of Craving and Subtler Layers of Clinging

In the sequence *phassa* → *vedanā* → *taṇhā*, a practitioner usually notices *kāma-taṇhā* first: the urge to prolong a pleasant feeling, repeat it, or get rid of an unpleasant one. Craving is not, however, limited to sensual pleasures. There are also *bhava-taṇhā*, craving for existence, and *vibhava-taṇhā*, craving for non-existence.

Kāma-taṇhā manifests as the urge for pleasant sensual experience: “I want to feel this,” “I want more.” *Bhava-taṇhā* is more deeply connected with becoming itself: to be, to continue, to become established in a particular mode of existence. They can support one another, but they are distinct kinds of craving.

The weakening or temporary cessation of sensual craving is not in itself *Nibbāna*. Clinging may continue in a subtler form: as the urge to be someone, preserve a particular state, continue to exist, or, conversely, cast off both an unpleasant experience and oneself as its experiencer.

Intentional actions arising in this process may become new *kamma* and bring corresponding results.

An unpleasant feeling may become harsh speech; a pleasant one, indulgence; neutral boredom, intoxication; a sense of lack, appropriation; fear, violence. The precepts do not merely prohibit consequences. They help reveal the early conditions of action.

Vedanā Is Not a Reaction

Vedanā is not an emotion and not a story about what is happening, but the tone of experience: pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral. Emotion usually arises further along, when the mind begins to react to this tone.

An emotion is usually broader than *vedanā*. Perception, intention, bodily tension, a story, and the state of mind already participate in it. An unpleasant tone of contact is therefore not yet anger, but under ignorance it may quickly become a role: “I am offended,” “I am defending myself,” “I must respond.”

A pleasant feeling easily becomes a condition for “I want more.” An unpleasant one becomes a condition for “remove, reject, destroy.” The neutral is often barely noticed and becomes a condition for boredom, fixation, or the search for a more vivid object.

Practice begins by recognizing feeling as feeling: pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral, arisen through conditions. Such recognition makes it possible to notice the subsequent reaction, but does not by itself end *taṇhā*. As understanding becomes clearer and guarding the sense doors, right effort, mindfulness, collectedness, and wisdom grow stronger, the mind clings to the pleasant, resists the unpleasant, and overlooks the neutral less and less.

Recognizing an unpleasant *vedanā* does not mean immediately trying to get rid of it. After “this is unpleasant,” a new *taṇhā* may arise: “may this disappear,” “I need to hide,” “I need to guarantee safety,” “I understood the chain, so why is the feeling still here?”

The task is not to remove *vedanā* at once, but to notice the subsequent reaction and not pick it up. The feeling itself can be observed as a conditioned and changing process.

Already arisen *dukkha* can become a condition for new *dukkha*: rejection of suffering gives rise to “may this not be,” “I want this to stop.” Thus *dukkha* arises because of *dukkha*. It is important to see this second layer as well, without reinforcing it with craving for cessation and without turning one instance of suffering into a whole factory of new darts.

How the Chain Unfolds Differently

The ordinary chain proceeds quickly: contact, feeling, craving, clinging, becoming, and *dukkha*. Practice does not destroy contact or feeling. It changes what happens after feeling.

When there are *sati*, clear comprehension, and collectedness, feeling can be recognized as feeling. Instead of the automatic “I want,” “I do not want,” or “I do not notice,” clear seeing becomes possible: this arose through conditions, changes, and is not “mine.” The link between *vedanā* and *taṇhā* is thereby weakened, and the mind develops an inclination toward letting go.

How to Investigate Sensual Pleasure

A pleasant *vedanā* in itself requires neither continuation nor elimination. It arises under the relevant conditions and ceases when the conditions change. *Kāma-taṇhā* appears in the next movement: “I want more,” “may this continue,” “I want it again.”

Trying to exclude pleasant experiences merely because they may become a condition for craving can itself turn into craving to get rid of them. Practice here consists in letting the pleasant remain simply pleasant, without appropriation, craving, or holding on.

Guarding the sense doors is not reducible to avoiding attractive objects or suppressing reactions. With contact, pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral *vedanā* arises. Under *avijjā*, feeling may become a condition for *taṇhā*: the mind demands that the pleasant be prolonged, the unpleasant removed, or the neutral background filled.

In [AN 6.63](#), *kāma* is explained not as attractive objects themselves, but as the desire and passion directed toward them.

In [MN 13](#), sensual experience is investigated from three sides:

assāda - gratification, pleasure, and joy,
ādīnava - danger, unreliability, and cost,
nissaraṇa - escape through abandoning desire and passion.

The aim is not to convince oneself that a pleasant object is actually unpleasant. Gratification is to be known as gratification. At the same time, it is important to see what conditions it depends upon, how quickly it changes, what the mind demands after it ends, and what the cost of repetition is.

Intentional abstention from sensual pleasure is not in itself *vibhava-taṇhā*: restraint may form part of ethical conduct, guarding the senses, and right effort. The extreme begins when the mind cultivates hatred of the pleasant, tries forcibly to destroy desire, or turns practice into a struggle against itself.

It is especially important to notice that sensual pleasure is often used not for the sake of

the object itself, but as an anesthetic for unpleasant *vedanā*: fatigue, loneliness, anxiety, boredom, or inner tension. The practical question is then not only “what do I want?” but also “what state is the mind trying to numb with this?”

In a particular episode, the way out may involve pausing, changing the conditions, meeting the actual need in another way, using the object in moderation, or completely abstaining. The deeper way out is that desire and passion lose their power, while pleasant feeling no longer demands continuation, repetition, or retention.

Metaphors for *taṇhā*

The suttas often explain *taṇhā* through images. It frequently appears as a habit, “just a little more,” fear of loss, a wish to repeat, a wish to become someone, or a wish that something not exist.

In [Dhp 334](#), craving is compared to a creeping vine: in a heedless person it grows. In the same way, a small concession, if unseen, gradually becomes a direction of mind. A person seized by craving is then compared to a monkey seeking fruit: the mind leaps from one object to another, hoping to find satisfaction somewhere farther on.

In [Dhp 335–336](#), craving is linked to the image of grass that grows again after rain. The outward manifestation can be cut down, but if the root is not recognized, the tendency sprouts again when suitable conditions appear. Practice therefore works not only with the action, but also with *vedanā*, *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, and the mind’s latent readiness to follow the same familiar route again.

In [SN 35.28](#), the Buddha says that the six sense fields, contact, and feelings burn with the fires of greed, hatred, and delusion. Pleasant feeling promises warmth, but when fed by clinging it becomes fuel for craving. What is seen, heard, sensed, and thought then becomes fuel for “I want,” “I do not want,” “may it be mine,” and “may it disappear.”

In [AN 6.61](#), craving is called a seamstress. It stitches separate contacts, feelings, memories, and expectations into a story: “this is me,” “this is mine,” “I was like this,” “I will be like this.” A fabric of *bhava* is thus woven from separate conditioned processes.

In [MN 75](#), indulging sensual craving is compared to scratching itchy sores. Scratching brings brief relief, but damages the wounds and strengthens the need to scratch again. Likewise, a pleasant object may genuinely give pleasure or temporarily relieve tension, but it does not remove craving and may strengthen tendencies.

In [Dhp 347](#), beings carried away by passion are compared to a spider caught in its own web. The mind itself weaves expectations, roles, fears, and attachments, and then suffers within what it has constructed.

In [SN 36.6](#), painful feeling is compared to a first dart, and mental suffering to a second. This shows that pain and *dukkha* are not the same. The first dart may arise through conditions, but the second is created by resistance, craving, and mental proliferation.

In [SN 35.63](#), it is said that if craving has not been abandoned, it remains a companion even for one who has gone to the forest. Seclusion by itself therefore does not liberate: one may be physically alone and still live together with craving.

These metaphors point to one thing: *taṇhā* does not cease through satiation. It loses strength when its conditions, its flavor, its danger, and the ways of letting it go are seen.

Example: a Chocolate Bar

Contact: seeing a chocolate bar or remembering its taste.

Vedanā: a pleasant feeling connected with anticipation arises.

Taṇhā: “I want to get it,” “I want comfort,” “I want a reward.”

Upādāna: “I need this,” “I deserve it,” “the evening is not right without it.”

Bhava: “I, the one who needs something pleasant,” “I, the tired one entitled to a reward,” or conversely, “I, the practitioner who must not want.”

Jarāmaraṇa: the pleasure will end; heaviness, guilt, desire for more, irritation, or renewed tension around control may follow.

The practical choice may differ. Sometimes one may calmly eat a little, without the myth “this will save me.” Sometimes it is better not to eat, because it is clear that this is an attempt to cover fatigue, anxiety, or boredom. The problem is not the chocolate, but the chain:

pleasant feeling → “I need it” → “I cannot do without it” → “I must get it.”

Three sides of the experience can be distinguished here.

Assāda: the chocolate really has a pleasant taste and provides pleasure and brief relief.

Ādīnava: the pleasure ends quickly and does not fully remove the fatigue, anxiety, boredom, or dissatisfaction from which the mind was trying to escape. If the pattern repeats, the mind memorizes the path and a habit forms. New craving, heaviness, guilt, or a struggle against oneself is added to the initial tension.

Nissaraṇa: seeing the demand and not indulging it automatically. Pleasant feeling arises and ends. The unpleasant can be experienced directly without an immediate attempt to numb it. If the body genuinely needs food, water, or rest, the need is met calmly, without turning it into a reward, salvation, or confirmation of a self-image.

15. *Satipaṭṭhāna*: the Four Establishments of Mindfulness

Satipaṭṭhāna is not the observation of “everything indiscriminately,” but clear mindfulness of body, feeling, mind, and *dhammā* as arising, conditioned, and impersonal processes. This practice operates within the integrated path: *sīla*, *indriya-saṃvara*, *sati*, *samādhi*, and *paññā* support one another.

Sati itself is also conditioned: it arises, strengthens, and weakens depending on causes such as *sīla*, energy, clarity, collectedness, wise attention, and the absence of coarse hindrances. Awakening does not mean permanent “24/7 awareness” as an unchanging state. More important is that experience is no longer appropriated as “I” and no longer feeds *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, and *bhava*.

Establishment	Practice	Error
<i>kāyānupassanā</i>	Body as body: breathing, postures, elements, actions, dissolution.	“This is my body, and I must constantly subject it to my will.”
<i>vedanānupassanā</i>	Pleasant, unpleasant, and neutral <i>vedanā</i> .	Immediately turning feeling into a story, or romanticizing it.
<i>cittānupassanā</i>	Mind with or without craving, with or without hatred, collected or distracted.	Creating an “observer self.”

Establishment	Practice	Error
<i>dhammānupassanā</i>	The hindrances, <i>khandhā</i> , sense fields, <i>bojjhaṅgā</i> , and <i>ariyasacca</i> .	Theorizing instead of recognizing.

The formula “body as body” points to contemplation of a specific aspect of bodily experience, such as breathing, posture, parts of the body, or elements. In [MN 118](#), breathing is treated as a bodily process. It can therefore be observed as a distinct object of body contemplation; it is not necessary to encompass every bodily sensation simultaneously.

In contemplating feelings, one distinguishes pleasant, unpleasant, and neutral *vedanā*, and each of these as *sāmisā* or *nirāmisā*. *Vedanā* means the tone of experience, not emotion in the broad sense.

Sāmisā is feeling with worldly, sensual nourishment; *nirāmisā* is without that nourishment and is connected with renunciation. *Nirāmisā* therefore cannot be reduced only to pleasant feeling or only to *samādhi*. For example, pleasure based on the five strands of sensual pleasure is *sāmisā*, while the pleasure of jhāna is *nirāmisā*; the same distinction is applied to unpleasant and neutral *vedanā* as well.

In practice, it is important to see not only whether *vedanā* is pleasant, but also the conditions from which it arises and whether it continues through *taṇhā* and clinging.

Dhammānupassanā is contemplation of *dhammā* as *dhammā*: hindrances, factors of awakening, and other practical categories of the Dhamma. One recognizes not only whether the relevant phenomenon is present, but also the conditions of its arising and cessation. In the case of a hindrance, one investigates what feeds it and what leads to its abandonment; in the case of a factor of awakening, what promotes its arising and further development.

Observing *citta*

In contemplating *citta*, it is important to see not so much the content of thoughts as the coloration of the process as it changes with conditions. One can see *citta* with craving or without craving, with aversion or without aversion, with delusion or without delusion, collected or distracted, contracted or expansive, liberated or not liberated. Instead of “why am I thinking about this again?” one can see: now the process is colored by irritation; now by desire; now by confusion; now it has become gentler. The coloration arises, changes, and ceases through conditions, without being “I” or “mine.”

Practices of *satipaṭṭhāna*

[MN 10](#) and [DN 22](#) list breathing, postures, clear comprehension of actions, parts of the body, elements, cemetery contemplations, feelings, states of mind, and *dhammā*. Their task is to teach one to see body as body, feeling as feeling, mind as mind, and phenomena as phenomena, without appropriation.

It is useful to distinguish directed contemplation from open practice. In the first, attention remains with one field: breathing, elements, *vedanā*, mind, or *dhammā*. In the second, once the mind is stable, processes may appear within a broad field: sound, sensation, thought, feeling, intention. The criterion is the same: are arising, cessation, conditionality, and non-appropriation visible?

In daily life, it is not necessary to track the whole chain constantly. With sufficiently developed mindfulness and wisdom, the process is noticed at the relevant moment.

The conditioned nature of attention does not mean that it should be left to drift. Intention, recollection, and the direction of attention are also developed as conditioned processes. No separate “controller” is needed: it is enough to create conditions under which attention leads to clearer seeing and the cessation of *dukkha*.

The Body as Elements

In [MN 10](#), the body is contemplated as consisting of the four great elements. More detailed examples of internal and external elements are given in [MN 28](#). Here the names “earth,” “water,” “fire,” and “air” are best understood not as four separate substances, but as qualities of bodily experience:

- the earth element: hardness, solidity, and resistance;
- the water element: liquidity, moisture, and fluidity;
- the fire element: temperature, warming, aging, and digestion;
- the air element: movement, pressure, expansion, contraction, inhalation, and exhalation.

It is useful first to feel the body as a whole and then notice these qualities in turn. There is no need to seek a “pure” element or imagine particles: several qualities are usually combined in a single experience. In the foot, for example, hardness, pressure, movement, warmth, and moisture may all be present at once.

One may then compare the internal and the external. The hardness of bones and the hardness of the floor, bodily warmth and external warmth, belong to the same kinds of conditioned qualities. In [MN 28](#), internal and external elements are regarded in the same way: as not mine, not me, and not my *attā*.

Practice is not reducible to repeating this formula. One should notice how the qualities arise through conditions, change, and do not submit to complete control. The body is then seen not as a single unchanging thing that belongs to me or is me, but as a combination of conditioned processes.

A Short Sequence

1. Feel the whole body and its contact with its support.
2. Notice hardness, solidity, and resistance.
3. Notice liquids, moisture, and fluidity.
4. Notice warmth, coolness, and changes in temperature.
5. Notice breathing, pressure, expansion, contraction, and other movement.
6. See that the qualities combine, change through conditions, and have no separate owner.

When the mind is simultaneously clouded and agitated, it can sometimes help to begin with the earth element: feel the weight of the body, the feet, and the support beneath them, move attention downward from the head, and then turn to natural breathing. This is a way of grounding and collecting attention, not a practice involving hidden energy.

A Mind Like the Elements

In MN 62, the elements are also used as images of a stable and unshaken mind. Rāhula is instructed to develop a mind like earth, water, fire, air, and space, so that pleasant and unpleasant contacts that arise do not seize the mind or remain in it.

Elements as “Not Self”

Contemplation of the elements does not end with recognizing solidity, fluidity, heat, movement, or space. In MN 62, the internal and external elements are regarded in the same way:

“This is not mine, I am not this, this is not my *attā*.”

Six Elements and Eight Attainments

The early suttas explicitly list six elements:

1. earth;
2. water;
3. fire;
4. air;
5. space;
6. consciousness.

The first four describe qualities of form. The space element (*ākāsa-dhātu*) appears as cavities, openings, intervals, and empty space, through which bodily form has internal divisions and boundaries.

The consciousness element (*viññāṇa-dhātu*) means conditioned knowing of an object. It is not an eternal observer, pure, independent consciousness, or a hidden ground of the world: consciousness arises when the relevant conditions are present.

A correspondence may be drawn with the jhānas through earth, water, fire, and air, and with the *arūpa-āyatana* through:

5. space;
6. consciousness;
7. nothingness;
8. neither perception nor non-perception.

The seventh and eighth items are not listed as elements in the suttas.

Contemplation of an element is not identical with a jhāna or an *arūpa-āyatana*. Contemplation of the earth element is not in itself the first jhāna, contemplation of space is not the dimension of boundless space, and recognition of the consciousness element is not the dimension of boundless consciousness.

Contemplating the Body, Its Parts, the Elements, and Death Without Aversion

Contemplation of body parts, elements, and death is not intended to produce disgust toward the body or gloom. Its purpose is sobriety. The body is seen as body: composite, dependent, vulnerable, and not fully subject to will. This weakens enchantment, fear, and appropriation,

but should not turn into aversion. Such practices also often help calm the mind at the beginning of meditation.

Walking Meditation

Walking meditation (*caṅkama*) is not a secondary practice, but a natural continuation of *kāyānupassanā*. MN 10 and DN 22 say explicitly: when a practitioner is walking, they know, “I am walking”; when standing, sitting, or lying down, they know the corresponding bodily posture. Walking helps carry *sati* from motionless sitting into movement and daily life. It is also useful when there is drowsiness, heaviness after eating, or bodily discomfort.

A practical method:

- choose a level path or quiet area with few distractions;
- before beginning, align the body for a moment and establish the intention;
- walk at a natural pace, without turning walking into theatrical slowness;
- keep attention on sensations in the feet and legs, on the movement of the body as a whole, or on breathing; choose what works best;
- when the mind wanders into thought, gently notice this and return to the step;
- see walking as a process: lifting, moving, touching, pressure, shifts of balance, and the intention to walk.

Walking provides a clear way to observe *anattā*: steps occur through many conditions, including intention, balance, muscles, contact with the ground, attention, and habit. No owner can be found in a step; there are conditions, a conditioned process, movement, and knowing movement.

If anxiety arises while walking near other people, it is not necessary first to convince oneself that “nothing is wrong” or “nobody cares.” It is more useful to see the process itself:

- bodily tension or contraction;
- unpleasant *vedanā*;
- *saññā*: recognition of another person’s presence;
- *vitakka*: “they may notice me,” “what will they think?”;
- *papañca*: further scenarios;
- *taṇhā*: “I want not to be noticed,” “I want to control the situation,” “I want the anxiety to be gone.”

If there is no real need to change anything, it is not necessary to follow the arisen craving immediately by stopping the walk, checking the other person’s facial expression, inventing replies in advance, or trying to remove the anxiety.

Sati-sampajañña: Mindfulness and Clear Comprehension

In the standard formula of *satipaṭṭhāna*, the practitioner is described as *ātāpī sampajāno satimā*: diligent, clearly comprehending, mindful.

The formula also includes *vineyya loke abhijjhā-domanassaṃ*: having set aside covetous desire (*abhijjhā*) and distress (*domanassa*) in regard to the world. *Domanassa* here means unpleasant mental feeling, distress, or dejection.

Ātāpī means diligent and ardent. The word is literally associated with heat or burning, but here it is better understood as bright, sustained energy: not becoming distracted, not feeding the unwholesome, and maintaining the conditions for clarity.

Sati is mindfulness or recollection: the ability to remember the object, task, and direction of practice and, when distraction is noticed, return to them.

Sampajañña means clear comprehension: what is happening now, why an action is being performed, whether it is appropriate, and what consequences may follow.

Mindfulness does not require holding to an object at all costs while ignoring what is happening around one. In formal meditation and daily activity, the object and breadth of attention are chosen according to the task and conditions.

Vigilance

Vigilance means not losing sight of what is happening when a strong feeling or impulse arises. It is important to notice whether it begins to carry the mind along so strongly that the circumstances and consequences of an action are no longer taken into account.

This does not mean constantly “being on guard” or controlling every thought and every sensation, but the ability to notice in time when an impulse begins to turn into action without regard to conditions. With practice, this kind of seeing becomes natural.

Sati and Sensual Desire

The arising of sensual desire does not yet mean that mindfulness is completely absent. In [MN 10](#), the practitioner recognizes the presence or absence of *kāmacchanda*, the conditions of its arising, its abandonment, and its future non-arising.

Recognizing desire and following it are not the same. Right mindfulness does not make indulgence in sensuality part of practice. In [SN 47.5](#), the five hindrances, including sensual desire, are called a mass of the unwholesome, while the four establishments of mindfulness are called a mass of the wholesome.

In [MN 22](#), the monk Ariṭṭha claims that phenomena called obstructions do not obstruct one who indulges in them. The Buddha rejects this view and emphasizes the danger of sensual pleasures. Observing desire with mindfulness therefore cannot be confused with justifying or consciously feeding it: *sammā-sati* and indulgence in sensual craving direct the mind in opposite directions.

Right Observation and *anattā*

It is useful, but insufficient, merely to see “it came and went.” Right observation asks: was there *phassa*? What *vedanā* arose? Is there *taṇhā*? Is there *upādāna*? What mode of *bhava* is taking shape? Can this chain be left unfed?

The word “observe” is conventional. It should not be turned into a separate witness: “I am the one who is aware,” “I am the one who sees processes.” Nor does *anattā* mean the position “I do not exist.” Ideas such as “I understood that I do not exist,” “I observe the absence of self,” or “I do not exist, therefore anything is permitted” may still be subtle *bhava*.

In practice, *anattā* is disclosed in this way: a process is known as a process. There are conditions, contact, feeling, craving, clinging, and becoming. When this is clearly seen as composite, conditioned, impermanent, and subject to dissolution, the mind ceases to build “I” and “mine” around the process.

The same applies to recognition itself. An in-breath arises, is recognized, and ceases; an out-breath arises, is recognized, and ceases. There is no separate “observer”: recognition itself also arises and ceases through conditions.

This is especially important with thoughts. A thought is also *mano-samphassa*: it gives rise to *vedanā*, after which the mind may want to obtain, prove, hold, calm, or elaborate something.

The question is: “what does the mind want to obtain through this thought?” When this is seen, the thought ceases to be “mine” and is seen as a conditioned process.

Sense Fields, Feeling, and Story

In daily life, it is enough to notice through which sense field contact occurred and what *vedanā* arose. The mind then sees experience before a story grows around it. Instead of “he insulted me,” one may notice hearing, unpleasant feeling, aversion, and the impulse to respond. *Papañca* thereby receives less nourishment.

Thinking can itself be attractive. Planning, fantasy, argument, inner commentary, and memory create a sense of movement. This movement may be pleasant or stimulating, and the mind seeks it again. It is therefore important to see not only the content of thought, but also the feeling that arises through contact with it.

A Method for Working with a Restless Mind

When the mind is restless, it often tries to calm itself by thinking even more. One thought arises, then another, followed by a plan, an argument, a memory, a fantasy, an explanation, or a dialogue. It seems that with just a little more thinking, the mind will finally find safety, control, or a solution. Often, however, this merely continues the chain.

Such a stream of thought can be understood as *mano-samphassa*: a thought, image, plan, or memory becomes an object of mental contact. From that contact, *vedanā* necessarily arises; the mind may then want to continue the thought, remove it, prove something, console itself with it, or construct a new role from it.

A practical sequence:

1. Slow down and acknowledge: “mental contact has arisen.”
2. Recognize *vedanā*: pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral feeling.
3. See the thought as a thought: an image, phrase, scenario, or inner argument.
4. Ask: what does the mind want to obtain from this thought?
5. Find *taṇhā*: the desire to solve, retain, prove, control, remove, or fill emptiness.
6. Find *upādāna*: what the mind holds as “mine” - being right, an image, safety, a plan, anxiety, or the role of a practitioner.
7. Recognize *bhava*: what kind of “I” is taking shape - “I, the anxious one,” “I, the controller,” “I, the one who must finish thinking this through,” “I, the offended one,” or “I, the practitioner whose thoughts are interfering.”
8. Do not feed the chain further: gently return to the body, breathing, the step, *mettā*, or apply one of the methods in [MN 20](#).

The task is not to switch off thoughts or force the mind to become empty. The desire to get rid of thoughts can itself be *taṇhā*. Practice consists in seeing how a thought becomes food for craving, clinging, and becoming, and ceasing to nourish that process.

Mental contact may also take images, fantasies, memories, or a song or melody stuck in the mind as its object.

16. Nīvaraṇa and bojjaṅgā: Diagnosis and Balance

The five *nīvaraṇa* obstruct clarity. The seven *bojjaṅgā* support progress on the path. It is useful to understand what is happening in the mind.

A hindrance is better seen not as “my problem,” but as a conditioned process. It is important to notice whether it is present now, how it arose, what sustains it, under what conditions it weakens, and what helps prevent its future arising. Working with hindrances then becomes not a struggle against oneself, but an investigation of conditions.

Diagnosis: Seeing What Is Present and What Is Absent

Work with the *nīvaraṇa* begins with honest recognition. In [MN 5](#), it is emphasized that it is worse to have a stain and not recognize it than to have a stain and recognize it, because seeing it makes removal possible. The same applies to the hindrances: sensual desire, irritation, dullness, restlessness, or doubt must first be recognized as present.

But it is also important to see when a hindrance is absent. Otherwise the mind may again carelessly follow an attractive, irritating, or clouding object. It is therefore useful not only to ask, “which hindrance is present now?” but also to notice, “this hindrance is absent now; what conditions led to its arising, weakening, or absence?”

In [MN 9](#), right view is explained as understanding a phenomenon, its arising, its cessation, and the way leading to its cessation. The same scheme can be applied to the hindrances: what has arisen now, from what conditions, how it ceases, and what factor supports its non-arising.

How to Work with the Five *nīvaraṇa*

The five *nīvaraṇa* arise not only in meditation. They may obstruct clarity in conversation, work, study, and decision-making. In [AN 5.51](#), they are called obstructions of the mind that weaken wisdom and make it difficult to choose wisely for oneself and others.

In contemplation of *dhammā*, it is important to see whether a hindrance is present now; when it is absent, which conditions sustain that absence; how an unarisen hindrance arises; how an arisen hindrance is abandoned; and how an extinguished hindrance is not fed again.

A hindrance need not be defeated through forceful effort. It is often more useful to see what feeds it and stop providing that nourishment.

Hindrance	How it manifests	What to do
<i>kāmacchanda</i> - sensual desire	The mind is drawn to a pleasant image, taste, bodily sensation, fantasy, or plan for pleasure. The object appears to promise happiness.	See the attractive image as an image. Recognize <i>vedanā</i> and craving. Reduce sensual nourishment and gently return to breathing or the body. <i>Asubha</i> , contemplation of the impermanence of the pleasant, and restraint of the sense faculties may be useful.

<i>vyāpāda</i> - ill will	The mind argues, accuses, rejects, wants to punish, prove, or get rid of something. Sometimes ill will is directed not at a person but at the meditation object itself: breathing has become tiresome, the body is irritating, or practice seems boring or unbearable.	Recognize unpleasant <i>vedanā</i> and the wish to push away. Calm the body, breathing, and face. Develop <i>mettā</i>. If the irritation is directed at breathing, there is no need to force oneself to “endure the object”: one may gently find a pleasant, beautiful, calming, or subtler aspect of the breath, expand attention to the whole body, or temporarily shift to <i>mettā</i>. If there is an unresolved conflict, one may calmly note: “I will deal with this after meditation.”
<i>thīna-middha</i> - dullness and drowsiness	Cloudiness, heaviness, sinking, drowsiness, loss of clarity.	Check whether this is bodily fatigue or mental dullness. Sit more upright, open or half-open the eyes, and feel the whole body. If the body is genuinely exhausted or sleep-deprived, rest. If the mind is dull and scattered, apply enlivening conditions: light, movement, a shower, a walk, a clear posture, or recollection of the purpose of practice. During the session, one may use a rapid scan of bodily sensations as they arise and disappear. This restores interest, energy, and clarity, after which it becomes easier to turn to breathing. The absence of noticeable thoughts does not in itself imply clarity: silence may result from dullness and weakened perception.

<i>uddhacca-kukkucca</i> - restlessness and remorse	The mind leaps, plans, checks, argues, and searches for guarantees. With remorse, it returns again and again to what was done or left undone.	First reduce incoming stimulation and recognize the bodily side of agitation: tension, an impulse to act, and rapid or wavering breathing. If the mind cannot remain with a single breath, there is no need to force it against the object. Simplify the task: only the body, only the breath, only this step. Be content with what is already here and now. One may use a rapid scan of sensations: quickly notice their arising and passing until excess movement and the craving to switch objects are exhausted. Then turn to the body or natural breathing. If agitation returns, repeat the scan temporarily. If there was a real mistake, acknowledge it, resolve to repair what can be repaired at an appropriate time, and release the replaying.
<i>vicikicchā</i> - doubt	“Am I doing this correctly?” “Is this the right method?” “Does it make sense?” “Perhaps I need something else?” Doubt paralyzes practice.	Distinguish useful investigation from doubt that drains energy. Apply <i>yoniso manasikāra</i> : what is unwholesome now, what is wholesome, and what leads to the cessation of <i>dukkha</i> ? After the session, one may consult the suttas, ask an experienced practitioner, or clarify the method. During the session, do not feed doubt or doubt about the doubt itself; observe and let go.

Hindrances do not always appear one at a time. In a single episode the body may be heavy and drowsy while the mind is simultaneously restless, irritated, or seeking stimulation. This is not a new hindrance, but a combination of signs whose conditions should be investigated separately.

A rapid scan is useful when cloudiness and agitation occur together: changing sensations awaken the dull part of the mind while allowing the restless part to exhaust its need for constant changes of object.

It is useful to ask not only “which hindrance is present now?” but also “from what conditions did it arise?”: sleep, food, stress, sensual stimulation, echoes of the previous day, and so forth.

The antidote is therefore not selected by a single label: the body may need movement and light, while the mind needs less stimulation and a softening of irritation.

Restlessness itself can become an object of practice. Instead of analyzing each storyline, it is useful to recognize the quality of mind and its bodily manifestations: inner agitation, tension, an impulse to switch objects immediately, or to continue thinking. One can then investigate what feeds this state and what happens when the impulse is not followed.

The general criterion is this: if the chosen response leaves less *lobha*, *dosa*, and *moha*, less contraction, and more clarity, the direction is sound. If practice makes the mind rigid, proud, clouded, or anxious, the conditions and the manner of effort should be examined.

Important: use an antidote when it is needed, and set it aside once the hindrance has subsided. Discern what is most appropriate now.

Latent Tendencies: *anusaya*

Anusaya is a latent tendency that may remain unmanifest for a long time, yet under suitable conditions influence the further course of the process: the thoughts, perceptions, and reactions that arise.

Seven main tendencies are distinguished:

- *kāmarāgānusaya* - the tendency toward sensual attraction;
- *paṭighānusaya* - the tendency toward aversion;
- *diṭṭhānusaya* - the tendency toward views;
- *vicikicchānusaya* - the tendency toward doubt;
- *mānānusaya* - the tendency toward conceit;
- *bhavarāgānusaya* - the tendency toward becoming;
- *avijjānusaya* - the tendency toward ignorance.

A latent tendency and an already arisen hindrance are not the same thing. Doubt, for example, may remain entirely unmanifest for a long time. Under particular conditions it arises, and details that support it are more readily selected from what is happening; unclear points are filled in with assumptions, and the assumptions are taken as facts.

It is important to see the conditions under which the tendency manifests and not continue the chain that has arisen.

The relation of latent tendencies to *vedanā* is especially clear: pleasant feeling provides conditions for the tendency toward attraction, unpleasant feeling for the tendency toward aversion, and neutral feeling, when clarity is absent, for ignorance.

In practice, the process may be noticed like this:

latent tendency → suitable conditions → habitual bias in perception
→ *taṇhā*/aversion → *papañca* → sustained *bhava*.

What Nourishes Ignorance

In AN 10.61, ignorance is shown as a conditioned process:

association with unworthy people → hearing what is not true Dhamma
 → lack of confidence
 → improper application of attention
 → weaker recollection and clear comprehension
 → lack of sense restraint
 → unwholesome conduct
 → the five hindrances → *avijjā*.

In the reverse direction, AN 10.61 gives a mirror sequence: association with worthy people leads to hearing the true Dhamma, then to confidence, *yoniso manasikāra*, recollection and clear comprehension, sense restraint, the three kinds of wholesome conduct, the four *satipaṭṭhāna*, the seven factors of awakening, and finally knowledge and liberation.

Balance and the Seven *bojjhaṅgā*

A dull and scattered mind lacks wakefulness, clarity, energy, and liveliness. It holds an object poorly, misses what is happening, and tends toward passivity, daydreaming, cloudiness, or sleepiness. An agitated mind jumps rapidly from one object to another and is accompanied by bodily tension, restlessness, and an impulse to do something immediately. During a single day, or even a single session, these states may alternate or occur together.

Sati is always needed: without recollection, the mind notices neither a hindrance nor its absence, nor the factors of the path. But this is not merely “mindfulness.” It is recollection within the framework of the Dhamma: remembering the aim of the path and the present task, discerning what should be developed and what should be abandoned, and recognizing which tool is appropriate now.

For a dull mind, enlivening is useful: *dhammavicaya*, *virīya*, and a gentle *pīti*. Investigation here primarily means directly observing the arising and passing of phenomena. Right effort includes establishing conditions: adequate sleep, moderation in eating, movement, light, a shower, a walk, a comfortable posture, and preserving time for practice. In this context, *pīti* may appear as quiet enlivening joy and relief grounded in a wholesome support.

For an agitated mind, the words “calm down” and “concentrate” are not enough. *Passaddhi*, *samādhi*, and *upekkhā* indicate the direction, but the mind may first need a preliminary tool that allows excess movement to run its course and the craving for new stimulation to be released. Afterward it turns more naturally to the body, breathing, and stable collectedness.

The same method need not work every day. *Mettā* may help with ill will; a rapid scan of sensations may help with cloudiness or agitation; genuine exhaustion calls for rest. Skill consists not in loyalty to a single technique, but in choosing accurately and changing tools at the right time.

Rapid Scanning for a Dull or Agitated Mind

If the mind cannot collect around breathing because of dullness, distraction, or agitation, one may try the following:

1. Sit or lie down and recognize the present state of mind.
2. Notice the most evident bodily sensation: warmth, pressure, tingling, movement, tension, or another signal.

3. Do not penetrate, explain, or hold the sensation. See that it arose, changed, or disappeared.
4. Immediately move to the next sensation that has arisen. Attention moves rapidly through the body following the phenomena themselves.
5. Continue observing arising and passing without selecting a predetermined sequence of body parts.
6. As practice develops, sensations may become subtler and briefer. When the mind loses interest in constant switching and quiet appears, turn to natural breathing.
7. Know breathing wherever it is clearly felt today, not only at the nostrils.
8. If agitation grows again, return briefly to rapid scanning and then turn back to breathing.

With a dull mind, changing sensations awaken interest, energy, and clarity. With an agitated mind, the practice initially accords with the tendency to switch, but gradually and temporarily satisfies the craving for new objects. The mind stops grasping every signal and can remain more easily with one process of breathing.

The practice may take several minutes, a substantial part of a session, or the whole session. There is no need to set a fixed time or insist that it must be followed by *jhāna*. If today the mind merely arrives at a clearer and quieter state, that is enough.

It is easiest to begin with bodily sensations. Later, the same approach may be used with a brief thought, image, mood, or melody: it arose, was known, changed, and disappeared. Its content is not analyzed unless it persists and grows stronger.

As a separate variation, one may move through parts of the body from coarser to softer and more fluid, much as in [MN 10](#). The pace should be comfortable, without fuss or haste, but also without prolonged examination as though through a microscope.

When Deeper Investigation Is Needed

If a phenomenon does not disappear, becomes stronger, or repeatedly returns, rapid scanning may be replaced by investigation of causes and conditions. The practitioner recognizes a bodily sensation, feeling, or state of mind, determines whether the feeling is pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral, and examines what sustains the process. Its impermanence, conditionality, and the clinging connected with it can then be investigated. This is a different, slower mode of *dhammavicaya*.

Entry into practice need not be identical each time. Today *mettā* may help, tomorrow rapid scanning, and on another day simply breathing. The state of mind after sleep, work, and sensual contacts is formed anew through conditions each time.

17. *Mettā*, *asubha*, *indriya-saṃvara*, and *yoniso manasikāra*

Mettā

Mettā is goodwill or loving-kindness. It softens the mind, reduces *dosa*, and makes practice less dry. To prevent *mettā* from becoming a new identity, “I am kind,” or a way of controlling everything through gentleness, it too should be seen as a conditioned and interdependent process.

A short practice:

- May this being be safe.
- May this being be free from hostility.
- May this being be free from suffering.
- May this being live in well-being, as far as possible.

There is no need to force a special feeling out of oneself. One may relate to the body, breathing, sounds, other people, and the world without hostility or a drive to control them. Toward living beings, one may cultivate wishes for safety and freedom from suffering. Any gentleness and warmth that arise can be sustained as part of *mettā*, but not turned into a metaphysical entity or “my experience.”

In the practice of *mettā*, it is important not to forget oneself. This is not about self-centeredness or strengthening an image of “me,” but about oneself as a living being who is also subject to pain, fear, fatigue, and suffering, and who also needs goodwill.

The Four *brahmavihāra*

The four *brahmavihāra* are *mettā*, *karuṇā*, *muditā*, and *upekkhā*: goodwill, compassion, sympathetic joy, and equanimity.

Developing the *brahmavihāra* weakens sensual attraction and ill will, but by itself does not eliminate *avijjā* or lead to liberation. There is therefore no need to make them a separate central practice and try by effort to bring each state to perfection.

At the *anāgāmin* stage, when these fetters have been completely abandoned, the main obstacles to the unfolding of the *brahmavihāra* also disappear.

Dosa* and *adosa

Hostility does not cease by adding more hostility. This only feeds the chain: contact becomes unpleasant feeling, unpleasant feeling becomes rejection, and rejection becomes harsh speech, action, or conflict.

*Na hi verena verāṇi, sammantīdha kudācanaṃ;
Averena ca sammanti, esa dhammo sanantano.*

[Dhp 5](#) says that hostility is not stilled by hostility (*verena*); it is stilled by non-hostility (*averena*). This clearly shows the practical meaning of *adosa*. The point is not to approve of everything or become helpless, but not to feed *dosa* with new *dosa*. Action may sometimes need to be firm, but the mind does not have to become hostile.

In [Snп 1.8](#), the same principle is expressed practically: do not deceive, despise, or wish suffering upon another out of anger and rejection.

Asubha

Asubha does not mean hatred of the body. It is a sober seeing of the body as body: elements, processes, aging, illness, dissolution. The practice is useful against sensual enchantment and the idealization of form.

Indriya-saṃvara

Restraint of the sense faculties is not hatred of the world, but wise restraint in what one takes in through the senses. If the mind is constantly fed hyperstimulation, content, arguments, news, and gossip, *taṇhā* receives endless food.

If the mind is already caught, one may look away, close an app, end a conversation, or stop elaborating mental imagery. This is not necessarily suppression. Sometimes changing

external conditions is the wisest and simplest way to prevent the chain from receiving new nourishment.

Practice includes:

- noticing which signs and details seize attention again;
- not developing fantasy, inner argument, or the search for the next stimulus;
- reducing unnecessary incoming contacts that feed craving and irritation;
- pausing before responding;
- setting aside screen-free periods of silence.

Yoniso manasikāra

In [MN 2](#), wise attention is connected with the non-arising of new taints and the abandonment of those already arisen. In [SN 46.51](#), frequent attention to particular signs is called nourishment for the corresponding hindrances or factors of awakening.

Attention is therefore better understood not as a universal “fuel of mind,” but as a condition that strengthens the chosen direction. As a practical distinction, one may say that *sati* helps one not lose the object, task, and framework of practice, while *yoniso manasikāra* directs examination toward causes, consequences, and cessation: not “how can I obtain what I want?” but “what conditions are creating *dukkha* now, and which lead to its cessation?”

18. *Samādhi* and the *Jhānas*

Samādhi is not for accumulating spiritual experiences; it is for making the mind fit for its work. A collected mind is less disturbed by the *nīvaraṇa* and better able to see the sequence *vedanā - taṇhā - upādāna - bhava*. *Samatha* calms and collects the mind; *vipassanā* clarifies conditions and dispels *avijjā*. Without wisdom, even deep peace may become subtle clinging.

Samatha and *vipassanā* are not two competing paths. In [AN 4.170](#), four possibilities are described: insight preceded by tranquility; tranquility preceded by insight; their development in tandem; and a case in which the mind is initially seized by agitation concerning the Dhamma, but then becomes steady, settles, unifies, and concentrates.

In every case, the criterion is the arising and development of the path, the abandoning of fetters, and the eradication of underlying tendencies.

A practitioner moves toward liberation on two legs: right *samādhi* and wisdom. Without right *samādhi*, wisdom lacks a stable foundation; without wisdom, even deep collectedness remains a conditioned state and may become a basis for clinging.

***Sammā-samādhi* and the Other Factors of the Path**

In [MN 117](#), noble right collectedness is described as collectedness of mind supported by the other seven factors of the path: right view, intention, speech, action, livelihood, effort, and mindfulness.

Right collectedness is defined not merely by the depth or stability of a state, but by its development within the surrounding factors of the Noble Path and by its service in abandoning unwholesome states and developing liberating wisdom.

Samatha is better understood not as tightly compressed attention, but as calming and purifying *citta*. The hindrances make the mind coarse, agitated, heavy, or clouded; *samatha* gradually weakens this pressure.

Right collectedness is therefore neither drowsiness nor pleasant oblivion. It must combine gentle calming with wakeful clarity. If calm leads to fixation, loss of clarity, and unwillingness

to see conditions, it is not yet the collectedness that supports wisdom.

What Changes at the Level of Mind

The practice of *samādhi* helps one see mind as a conditioned process. In an ordinary state, it seems that “my mind” is simply like this: anxious, heavy, clear, sleepy, or restless. In practice, however, it becomes noticeable that the state of mind changes according to conditions.

The mind can be collected or uncollected, clear or clouded, gentle or tense, calm or agitated. Practice helps reveal that mind is not a permanent self or an owner of experience. It too arises, changes, and calms depending on causes.

When the mind is collected, contact becomes less chaotic, feelings are recognized more clearly, and the link *vedanā - taṇhā* is not triggered so sharply. Collectedness is therefore needed not for the sake of possessing a state, but to make the mind fit to see.

Jhāna as a Condition for Seeing

Samādhi is useful because the mind becomes collected, less seized by hindrances, and capable of seeing subtle phenomena. Without sufficient collectedness, the mind retains blind spots: the hindrances not only distort perception, but conceal their own influence. Jhāna does not guarantee wisdom, but the temporary abandonment of hindrances makes the mind better suited to a clear investigation of experience.

Jhāna remains a conditioned process. Its factors arise through conditions and cease through conditions. Even deep *samādhi* should therefore be seen in terms of *anicca*, *dukkha*, and *anattā*. If an image is built around jhāna, such as “I attained,” “I am special,” or “I must hold on to this,” it becomes food for *upādāna*, *māna*, and *bhava*.

Depth of Jhāna

What matters is not so much the speed with which one passes through the jhānas as the depth to which they unfold and are relinquished. Mastery of later jhānas does not mean that the earlier ones have already unfolded deeply enough.

Passing through all the attainments without wisdom does not liberate.

Sometimes clarity becomes blurred. This is not a deepening of jhāna, but cloudiness or *moha*. In the suttas, *moha* (delusion, mental obscuration) is named as one of the three unwholesome roots. As *samādhi* deepens, clarity and recollection should not disappear.

Constant evaluation within jhāna interferes with its deepening. Comparison with past sessions, impatience such as “when will the next one come?,” and forcing a transition bring unnecessary tension back into the process. It is better to leave evaluation until after emerging.

How to Approach Jhāna

Jhāna (*jhāna*) is not attained through tension. In practice, entry begins with *sīla*, *sati*, the temporary fading of the five *nīvaraṇa*, and a calm support such as breathing or the body. Seclusion in the formula of the first jhāna is not only physical but inward: the mind stops feeding sensual desire, irritation, dullness, restlessness, and doubt.

Effort should be neither rigid nor lax. Holding the object too tightly creates tension and quickly tires the mind; holding it too weakly does not allow collectedness to deepen. The appropriate degree of effort is discovered directly in practice: at times attention needs a little support, while at other times one needs instead to stop interfering and let go.

Different Entries into Collectedness

Breathing is not the only path into jhāna. Depending on the state and dispositions of the mind, collectedness may mature on the basis of *mettā*, practice with the elements, or another suitable object.

In *ānāpānasati*, the task is not to control breathing, but clearly to know inhalation and exhalation and progressively develop calming of body, feelings, and mind. As practice continues, the mind becomes calmer, clearer, and steadier, while attention is directed toward impermanence, cessation, and relinquishment. Breathing is to be seen not as “my breathing,” but as a process: an inhalation arises and ceases; an exhalation arises and ceases.

Viewed through the chain of conditions, breathing becomes an object of attention. There is the body, the process of inhalation and exhalation, mindfulness of that process, and clear comprehension of the state of mind. On this basis, mental contact arises, and with it *vedanā*. At first this is often neutral feeling: nothing special seems to be happening. Precisely here, the mind easily becomes bored, searches for another object, controls the breath, or becomes irritated with practice. When there are *sati* and an understanding of conditionality, neutral feeling is recognized as feeling, and the mind need not become agitated.

As calming develops, breathing becomes subtler and neutral feeling may be replaced by a subtly pleasant one. This is not a goal to chase, but a sign that coarser bodily formations are calming. If unusual images, light, a *nimitta*, or pleasant bodily sensations arise, they should be understood as conditioned processes: do not grasp, retain, or turn them into “my attainment.” They need not appear at all.

The depth of the same jhāna varies from session to session. Sleep deprivation, overeating, fatigue, illness, and intense prior stimulation can make it shallow or clouded. Differences between sessions depend to a large extent on the conditions of practice.

Jhāna has no mandatory duration. A predetermined thought such as “I will stay here for so many minutes and then move on” brings evaluation back into the process itself. When possible, it is better to set aside enough free time in advance so that practice is not constrained by a predetermined duration.

Breathing need not be made especially correct. Inhalation and exhalation arise through conditions and are known as a bodily process: not “I produce the breath,” but “breathing occurs and is known.” Attention need not contract to a single point at the nostrils. It is better to know the whole cycle and its manifestation in the body, while keeping the face relaxed, the posture stable, and clarity awake.

In [MN 36](#), the Buddha recollects the happiness of the first jhāna and understands that happiness secluded from sensuality and unwholesome states is not to be feared. When pleasantness and the first waves of *pīti* arise from seclusion and calming, the task is neither to earn them nor to appropriate an attainment. Such happiness need not be feared, but neither should it be intensified or possessed: it can simply be allowed to be, while doubt and clinging are released.

Pīti-sukha saturates and pervades the whole body. It is important that the pleasantness not remain only in the mind or become an object viewed from a distance. It should encompass and permeate the whole body.

The Pleasant in Practice and the Danger of Clinging

When the mind becomes sufficiently collected, *pīti* and *sukha* may arise. Both are pleasant aspects of experience, but they do not mean the same thing. *Pīti* is rapture, joyful enlivening,

or inspiration, while *sukha* is happiness, pleasantness, and inner comfort. In the first two jhānas, they are present together; in the third, *pīti* fades while *sukha* remains.

If the mind thinks, “I want more,” “this is mine,” “I attained,” or “I must retain it,” the pleasant becomes food for *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, and *bhava*. Even meditative happiness then becomes a condition for future *dukkha*: fear of loss, desire to repeat, and comparison with past experience.

If *pīti* and *sukha* are seen as having arisen through conditions, as impermanent and impersonal, the mind need not appropriate them. Rapture can then settle into happiness, happiness into quieter collectedness, and collectedness into equanimity. Transitions among the jhānas occur naturally: when the fuel sustaining a coarser state is exhausted, that state is no longer maintained, and the next jhāna matures without the deliberate thought, “I am moving on.”

It is more accurate to speak of jhāna not as an event, “I entered a state,” but as a form of collectedness that arises when the necessary conditions are present and can be used in practice. It is not an unconscious blackout: clarity and awareness remain, though thinking quiets. Jhāna is a conditioned process; if afterward there arises “I want to repeat this” or “this is my attainment,” it becomes a condition for *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, and *bhava*. Descriptions of jhāna occur in many suttas, for example [MN 119](#).

After practice, it is important not only to determine which jhāna arose, but also to see what the mind has become like. A deeper unfolding usually leaves behind noticeable clarity, stability, and less inclination to cling to stimulation. Does the mind seek stimulation less, react less irritably to the unpleasant, cling less to the pleasant, and recognize *vedanā* and *taṇhā* more quickly during the day? If meditation increases pride, hunger for states, fear of losing an experience, or irritation over an “unsuccessful practice,” a new *bhava* is already being built around *samādhī*.

The Threshold of Jhāna

At early stages, the first jhāna may be unstable. *Pīti*, *sukha*, clarity, and collectedness may be present, while brief thoughts, doubt, or wariness still arise at the periphery: “is this jhāna?” “someone may distract me,” “I will lose this state.” This is either a pre-jhāna state or an entry into the first jhāna followed by being thrown out again, like a yo-yo.

This may be called the threshold of jhāna. It is a stage at which breathing has already become subtle and pleasant, the five hindrances have markedly weakened, and *pīti-sukha* has arisen, but fluctuations remain. Waves of *pīti* may occur even before the first jhāna. Here it is worth letting go, not clinging, trusting, and yielding to the process.

When rapture arises, attention should be turned toward it and allowed to settle into it. It may then begin to grow, a kind of resonance may develop, and this may be followed by absorption in it. At this point, the breath is let go. One should not try to intensify rapture through tension, hold it, or encompass it all at once. If rapture fades, that is all right. One may return to breathing or attend to the residual image of rapture, its afterglow, like the trace left by a lamp that has just been switched off. One may also establish the intention to fill with rapture on the in-breath and spread it through the body on the out-breath. Overall, this is a highly creative process.

In [AN 10.72](#), [external] sound is called a “thorn” for the first jhāna. This may be understood as a warning about the vulnerability of collectedness that has not yet been fully mastered.

It is useful to notice fear of losing the state. The thought “I am about to lose this” reveals subtle *upādāna*: the pleasant state is already being appropriated as “my attainment.” Practice here is not a struggle against anxiety, but clear knowing: “fear has arisen,” “there is a wish

to retain,” “this is a conditioned process.” This is to be released, and attention gently returns to rapture or its image, breathing, or the body.

Unusual bodily, luminous, or spatial effects are not the main criterion of jhāna. More important are whether the five *nīvaraṇa* have weakened, whether stability, clarity, *pīti*, *sukha*, and collectedness are present, and whether there is less clinging to the state itself. Entry through a nimitta understood as a reflection of a mind purified of the hindrances is not described in the suttas, but is quite possible in practice. It may arise with rapture or without it.

In [AN 9.35](#), a practitioner is compared to a mountain cow that loses its former footing by trying to step farther too soon. Wholesome collectedness that has arisen should be developed, mastered, and strengthened, without trying to force the next state. This is not inaction, but right effort without craving for a result. On the other hand, one should not deliberately hold back either. Jhānas are always different and occur in different ways.

What Can Throw One Out of the First Jhāna

Most often, one of the following occurs:

- recognizing success and grasping it: “great, it worked,” “I entered”;
- trying to intensify or retain *pīti*;
- fear of unfamiliar intensity or loss of control;
- doubts such as “is this it?” or “perhaps this is not it,” and fussing over the factors;
- effort that is too tense or too slack;
- the return of a residual hindrance;
- a hidden prohibition against happiness: “I am unworthy”;
- a question about the future: “what will I do after something like this?”;
- fear of falling after a pleasant peak;
- comparison with past experience.

Absorption Without Unconsciousness

Jhāna is not an unconscious shutdown, but neither is it merely an ordinary pleasant state, such as enjoyment of a beautiful sunset. Awareness and clarity remain and may become very strong, while *pīti-sukha* and unification of mind become the leading current of experience.

An external sound or bodily signal may flicker at the periphery without provoking interest, resistance, or a continuation in thought. Worldly contact passes by because the mind is absorbed in happiness born of seclusion and collectedness. In deeper absorption, the significance of external experience may diminish still further. One should not assume in advance that it will always be possible to switch instantly from deep collectedness to an urgent everyday task. Such practice is therefore best planned for free time.

Unusual Phenomena and *nimitta*

As collectedness deepens, flashes of light, changes in the body image, inner sounds, or mental images may arise. They are not obligatory signs of jhāna.

In the early texts, *nimitta* means a sign, mark, or aspect. A special luminous image used as an object of absorption belongs to a narrower, later use of the term. Some modern methods use a stable luminous or other mental image as a support, but a voice, narrative, melody, or image of a being should not automatically be declared a *nimitta*.

The First and Second Jhānas: Direction and Self-Sustaining Collectedness

No two *jhānas* are completely identical. Even a first or second *jhāna* in the same practitioner may differ in depth, intensity, duration, and in how vividly particular factors appear. One should therefore not demand an exact repetition of a past experience.

The main practical distinction between the first and second *jhānas* lies not in the character of the waves of *pīti*, but in the presence or absence of *vitakka-vicāra*. In the first *jhāna*, attention is still directed toward the object and continues to be sustained there. In the second, directed and sustained application subside, while collectedness becomes inwardly unified and self-sustaining.

In the first *jhāna*, *pīti-sukha* may be experienced as intense waves that still require gentle direction and the mind's continued abiding with the pleasant experience. A wave may grow, recede, and then rise again.

In the second *jhāna*, *pīti* may also come in waves. It may be experienced less as rapture and more as joy, but the central point is that the mind no longer needs to be directed toward and sustained on the object.

The Third and Fourth Jhānas: Calming and Stillness

In the third *jhāna*, *pīti* calms while *sukha* remains. In practice, this may be experienced as a quiet, light, contented well-being: the mind feels good, but the pleasantness no longer excites or arrives in waves as it does in the first two *jhānas*. Pleasant warmth may spread throughout the body; sometimes it feels as though the whole body is gently smiling. A contented peace arises: everything is well and nothing is required. These images are not obligatory criteria. Experience of the third *jhāna* brings an understanding of the difference between *sukha* and *pīti*.

In the fourth *jhāna*, pleasant and unpleasant feelings have been abandoned. Clarity, one-pointedness, and stillness become prominent. The mind may be experienced as a monolith, ice, a motionless current, crystal, or transparent glass. The whole body remains clearly perceptible. Experiences may include neutral heaviness, transparency, a frozen quality, and clarity. There is firmness and confidence in the unshakability of the mind.

Deep peace by itself is not yet the fourth *jhāna*. The fourth unfolds as the result of the fading of the factors of the preceding *jhānas*. The first, second, and third may pass very quickly, but the sequence of refinement itself remains.

When Ripples Remain on the Surface

If a separate thought or restlessness remains at the periphery, one may gently try one of three approaches:

1. On a natural in-breath, imagine that the thought or fluctuation becomes joined to the air and, on the out-breath, leaves with the flow.
2. Slowly move attention through the body, evening out the stillness. One may use an image of water dripping onto hot ice while the entire body quietly freezes in the same way. The abdomen remains free for natural breathing; the muscles, face, and eyes are not tensed.

3. Apply discernment through wisdom: “this is not mine, this is not me, this is not my essence.” The thought or restlessness is seen as a process arisen through conditions. When appropriation receives no nourishment, the phenomenon may disperse like smoke from a struck match.

If deep collectedness has become excessively concentrated in the head, a sense of imbalance has appeared, or the eyelids have tensed, it is useful to relax the face and gently distribute collectedness throughout the whole body.

A Stable *nimitta*

If the same stable mental sign recurs, one may direct a spotlight of attention toward it, enter it, and become absorbed. The point is not to remain in the stance “I am looking at that,” but to follow it with attention and merge with it.

It makes sense to move toward the dimension of boundless space when the fourth jhāna has become stable, deep, and thoroughly familiar.

Insights Based on Jhānic Collectedness

Samādhi and wisdom deepen interdependently: collectedness makes subtler clinging visible, while recognizing and letting go of that clinging allows practice to deepen further.

Jhānic collectedness is not an end in itself, but without it insights may remain superficial or even become mentally painful. This does not refer to physical pain. Fear and terror arise when the collapse of familiar supports of “I” and “mine” is revealed to a mind not yet strengthened by jhāna.

As one progresses through the jhānas, *bhava* is partly relinquished: layers of becoming fall away. This is not yet final liberation, but the mind approaches insight with less inclination to cling and is better prepared to receive what is seen.

Insights sometimes arise during jhāna and sometimes afterward, but deliberate investigation is usually better conducted after emerging, while the mind is still fresh and collected. It is also useful after emerging to review the experience and see the conditions on which it depended, how it arose, changed, and ceased. Jhāna too is conditioned and impermanent.

Dependent Origination After Jhāna

After emerging from deep collectedness, one can examine a process that is clearly present, such as a feeling, bodily sensation, sound, thought, anxiety, or another contact, and trace its conditions.

For example, if a pleasant feeling has arisen, one can see what contact conditioned it, which sense fields were involved, whether craving arises following the feeling, and what happens when the process is not sustained by clinging.

Insight may arise after jhāna, at the boundary of its ending, or during it. Sometimes collectedness weakens for a moment, the process is clearly recognized by wisdom, and then *samādhi* deepens again.

Such understanding may accumulate gradually. The same process is examined from different angles until, at some point, its conditionality, impermanence, unsatisfactoriness, and impersonal nature become clear enough for natural letting go.

After emerging, it is useful to see how the state was formed: intention, direction of mind, perception, sustained attention, and one’s relation to what arose came together through

conditions and supported the attainment. In this sense, jhāna is *saṅkhata*, a compounded and conditioned state. The *saṅkhārā* connected with it are formative processes that arise, perform their function, and cease.

[AN 9.36](#) shows how a jhāna or formless dimension becomes a basis for liberating vision. Relying on the attainment, a practitioner regards the phenomena connected with it as impermanent, unsatisfactory, disintegrating, empty, and impersonal. In this way, the conditionality, limitations, and drawbacks even of a very subtle and pleasant state are revealed.

In the same sutta, the development of liberating vision is compared to the training of an archer. At first the archer practices on a straw target or clay figure and, over time, becomes capable of shooting far and accurately. In the same way, contemplation of conditioned phenomena develops through repeated use of a collected mind fit for work.

The mind then turns away from the conditioned and inclines toward the Deathless: the calming of all formative activities, the relinquishment of every appropriation, the cessation of craving, dispassion, cessation, and *Nibbāna*. If this work is completed, the defilements cease. If not, it may still result in the ending of the five lower fetters and the attainment of non-returning.

It is therefore useful not only to develop and master jhāna, but also, after emerging, to see it as a process that arose according to conditions. Its happiness need not be rejected, but neither should it be clung to: collectedness is used to free the mind from appropriation, not to create a new identity.

Four Purposes of Collectedness

[AN 4.41](#) names four directions in the development of *samādhi*.

Development of collectedness	Practical function
The four jhānas	Pleasant abiding here and now.
Perception of light	Knowledge and vision.
The practitioner knows when feelings, perceptions, and thoughts (<i>vitakka</i>) arise, are present, and cease	Mindfulness and clear comprehension.
Contemplating the arising and cessation of processes belonging to the five clinging-aggregates	Cessation of the <i>āsavā</i> .

Collectedness may provide wholesome peace, strengthen clarity, and become a basis for the cessation of defilements. The question “was it pleasant?” is therefore insufficient. It is important to understand what function the practice is serving now and what result it is tending toward.

Impermanence, Dispassion, Cessation, and Relinquishment

In [MN 118](#), *ānāpānasati* is described as contemplation of impermanence, dispassion, cessation, and relinquishment. This is what a rightly collected and clear mind gradually leads toward.

First, impermanence becomes more visible. An inhalation arises and ceases; an exhalation arises and ceases. No two inhalations or exhalations are identical. The feeling associated with breathing changes: the neutral may become subtly pleasant, pleasant feeling may become subtler, and *pīti* and *sukha* also arise and cease. Even calm and collectedness depend on conditions.

As impermanence is seen more deeply, passionate clinging to experience weakens. This is *virāga*: the cooling of greedy grasping at what cannot be held.

Cessation then becomes clearer. What has arisen through conditions ceases when those conditions cease. Through practice, the mind begins to understand directly, not merely as an idea, that nothing conditioned can be a reliable support for “I” and “mine.”

From this, relinquishment unfolds more naturally. It is not reducible to the thought “I must let go.” Rather, the mind stops habitually grasping the pleasant, pushing away the unpleasant, and failing to notice the neutral. The chain receives less nourishment.

Temporary Abandonment and Final Cessation

The absence of the five hindrances in deep collectedness is not equivalent to their final eradication. After emerging, the corresponding tendencies may manifest again. [AN 4.123](#) shows that a person may enjoy *jhāna*, desire its repetition, and thereby obtain a corresponding rebirth without attaining liberation.

The depth and pleasantness of a state are therefore not in themselves measures of liberation. What matters is whether collectedness is used to develop wisdom and weaken *taṇhā*, *upādāna*, and ignorance.

Important: *jhāna* does not liberate automatically, and not every pleasant meditative state is *jhāna*. *Jhānas* can become objects of clinging, grounds for pride, and causes of new *bhava*: “I am an impressive practitioner,” “I attained a special state,” or “I must repeat this.” Even deep collectedness should therefore be seen as a conditioned process, not as a possession or a final experience.

19. The Formless Dimensions (*arūpa āyatana*) and *nirodha*

After mastering the fourth *jhāna*, it is not necessary to move immediately to the formless dimensions. It is useful first to become thoroughly familiar with the fourth *jhāna* and establish a well-worn path back to it.

As a working metaphor, the reserve of *sati*, clarity, and one-pointedness can be imagined as a “tank.” The fourth *jhāna* serves as its main “refueling” point: accumulated collectedness becomes fuel for further practice and for the opening of the formless dimensions.

The formless dimensions do not refill this “tank”; they use the collectedness already accumulated. If there is not enough fuel, the corresponding element may become discernible, but the *arūpa-āyatana* itself will not open or will quickly fade. When the reserve is depleted, it is therefore useful to return to the fourth *jhāna* and restore one-pointedness and clarity.

If the reserve of collectedness remains, a transition into a formless dimension may occur even without directly entering the *rūpa jhānas*.

With accumulated collectedness, there is no need to pass through the same sequence every time. In one session an earlier *jhāna* unfolds more deeply; in another the transition goes farther. There is no need to force transitions: deepening and letting go occur through conditions.

On the basis of the remaining collectedness, one may practice *satipaṭṭhāna*, especially contemplation of the body: its parts, elements, composite character, arising, change, and disintegration. Such practice helps weaken clinging to *rūpa*.

After the four *rūpa jhānas*, the suttas describe four formless dimensions: boundless space, infinite consciousness, nothingness, and neither-perception-nor-non-perception. These are

subtle attainments, not *Nibbāna*: they are conditioned and may become *bhava* if the mind clings to their peace, emptiness, or exceptional character. Their value is to reveal the coarseness of sensual experience and *rūpa* and to provide material for seeing *anicca*, *dukkha*, and *anattā* even in such subtle states.

Refining the Basis in the Formless Dimensions

Across the four *arūpa-āyatana*, progressively subtler supports are left behind. Yet each attainment remains conditioned and can become an object of clinging.

Their significance lies not only in the subtlety of collectedness, but also in the opportunity to discover clinging that is not visible during coarser functioning of the senses and consciousness.

The sequence of the formless dimensions is not important for its own sake. Its meaning lies in deepening experience and relinquishing increasingly subtle supports and forms of clinging. What matters here is not the speed of passing through attainments, but the depth with which the corresponding support is recognized and relinquished.

The four *rūpa* jhānas and four *arūpa-āyatana* form a progressive refinement of experience. Each successive stage makes a subtler layer of perception and clinging discernible.

The task is therefore not a one-time “touch.” The attainments need to unfold deeply enough for form, space, consciousness, nothingness, and then extremely subtle perception to be relinquished in succession. It is this depth that brings the practitioner toward direct recognition of the subtlest craving and toward *nirodha*.

The Eight Attainments as a Progressive Refinement of Perception

The usual short names are convenient, but DN 9 shows a more detailed side of the same sequence: at each stage the previous *saññā* ceases and a subtler one arises. For the first seven attainments, the text uses the expression *sukhuma-sacca-saññā*: subtle, actually present perception.

1. The first jhāna: subtle, actually present perception of rapture and happiness born of seclusion (*vivekaja-pīti-sukha-sukhuma-sacca-saññā*).
2. The second jhāna: subtle, actually present perception of rapture and happiness born of *samādhi* (*samādhija-pīti-sukha-sukhuma-sacca-saññā*).
3. The third jhāna: subtle, actually present perception of happiness together with equanimity (*upekkhā-sukha-sukhuma-sacca-saññā*).
4. The fourth jhāna: subtle, actually present perception of neither-pleasant-nor-unpleasant (*adukkhamasukha-sukhuma-sacca-saññā*).
5. The dimension of boundless space: subtle, actually present perception of boundless space (*ākāsānañcāyatana-sukhuma-sacca-saññā*).
6. The dimension of infinite consciousness: subtle, actually present perception of the dimension of infinite consciousness (*viññāṇaṇcāyatana-sukhuma-sacca-saññā*).
7. The dimension of nothingness: subtle, actually present perception of the absence of everything (*ākīñcaññāyatana-sukhuma-sacca-saññā*). Here it is more precise not to say “the practitioner perceives absence,” but rather that the process of subtle perception of absence itself remains.

8. The dimension of neither-perception-nor-non-perception (*nevasaññānāsaññāyatana*): perception has become so subtle that it can no longer be definitely called either perception or the absence of perception. The Chinese parallel DĀ 28 speaks of the arising of perception of this dimension and, in the transition to cessation, calls the remaining perception “subtle” (微妙想): this subtle perception ceases without being replaced by a coarser one.

For the eighth stage, the Pali DN 9 does not give a parallel formula with *sukhuma-sacca-saññā*: the ladder ends with the dimension of nothingness, after which the text speaks of the limit of perception (*saññagga*). The Chinese parallel DĀ 28 continues the sequence with the dimension of neither-perception-nor-non-perception.

The cosmological framework can also be understood as indicating levels of clinging. At the sensual level, the mind clings to pleasant objects. In *rūpa* and *arūpa* dimensions, clinging is subtler: not to an object, but to a state such as peace, space, consciousness, the absence of everything, or the subtle sense “it is good to be here.” Yet all of this remains conditioned.

From the Fourth Jhāna to the Dimension of Boundless Space

The appropriate moment arises when the fourth jhāna has matured and begins to end naturally: its “fuel” is running out, while clarity and one-pointedness still remain. During the jhāna itself, it is better not to try to switch the mind to something else. The transition becomes natural at the boundary where the fourth jhāna is ending.

Practice with the elements may be used separately as preparation for the transition. Its task is to see more deeply the composite nature of *rūpa* and cultivate a natural letting go of form. When the elements are recognized as conditioned processes and are no longer held on to, the grip on *rūpa* itself also weakens.

The space element can be recognized, for example, through the successive fading of the other elements. Earth, water, fire, and air are regarded as conditioned processes all the way to their cessation.

At first, space may still be perceived specifically as an element. For the transition to the first formless dimension, perceptions of form are completely left behind, and with a light intention to know boundless space, the transition takes place from the space element to the dimension of boundless space.

During the transition, there may be a sense of sudden opening or expansion: previously a bounded form was perceived, and then its boundaries are no longer held.

If contraction, expansion, movement, pressure, or “airiness” are still clearly felt afterward, this may indicate a continuing reliance on *rūpa*, in particular on the air element. In the established dimension, space no longer needs to be expanded: no boundary is found.

Boundlessness, Unity, and Expansion

The canonical formula describes the transition as follows:

- *sabbaso rūpasaññānaṃ samatikkamā* — with the complete transcendence of perceptions of form;
- *paṭighasaññānaṃ atthaṅgamā* — with the disappearance of perceptions of resistance;
- *nānattasaññānaṃ amanasikārā* — with non-attention to perceptions of multiplicity.

Of practical importance is the connection between leaving multiplicity behind and boundlessness. The first formless dimension can be described in practical terms as a single boundless

space: the multiplicity of forms has been left behind, the boundaries separating them are no longer found, and space is known as unified and boundless.

If Space “Freezes”

Sometimes, after coarse form has been left behind, space begins to be experienced as a motionless object that the mind seems to have discovered and is holding. There is no need to break this state by force. It is more useful to notice the holding itself and continue investigating the processes that arise within the attainment.

In [AN 9.36](#), after attaining the dimension of boundless space, *vedanā*, *saññā*, *saṅkhārā*, and *viññāṇa* are regarded as impermanent, unsatisfactory, disintegrating, empty, and “not self.” Boundless space should therefore not become a new support or *attā*.

Residual bodily sensations may remain during the transition. If attention begins turning toward them again, *rūpa* may once more become a support. It is also important to notice tension, the urge to “enter” the dimension, and attempts to accelerate the transition: all of this should be let go.

Sensations do not need to be suppressed or forcibly removed. It is enough not to use them to sustain bodily form and to allow the mind to become established in boundless space.

Similar guidance is given to Moggallāna in [SN 40.5](#).

If the Transition Does Not Come Together

In practice, it is useful to check several points.

1. **The fourth jhāna has not yet matured sufficiently.** If it is unstable, or an attempt to switch begins before its natural ending, the intention to move further turns into tension and disrupts collectedness.
2. **If intention has turned into pressure to achieve a result.** Intention itself does not obstruct practice. The problem arises when the attainment becomes a goal that must be reached as quickly as possible or “at any cost.” Then craving and tension appear in place of letting go.
3. ***Rūpa* is not yet being let go naturally.** If attention repeatedly returns to the body, boundaries, pressure, movement, or other signs of form, it is more useful to continue insight into the elements separately than to keep forcing the transition.
4. **A “yo-yo” pattern develops and tension accumulates.** When the mind repeatedly almost lets go of form, then grasps it again and once more tries to make the transition, the practice begins to become tiring. If noticeable tension of mind or body remains after the session, this is a good signal to stop pressing the transition, restore collectedness, and return to whatever condition still needs further development.

A Formless Dimension Is Not an Unconscious Shutdown

The formless attainments are not an unconscious shutdown. In [AN 9.36](#), in the examination of the dimension of boundless space, *vedanā*, *saññā*, *saṅkhārā*, and *viññāṇa* connected with it are listed, whereas *rūpa* is absent from the list.

The complete cessation of perception and feeling comes only after the dimension of neither-perception-nor-non-perception.

As this dimension is mastered, freedom, lightness, and subtle pleasantness may arise because form has ceased to be the leading support.

Even freedom from form and the experience of boundlessness may support subtle craving and clinging. The dimension should be mastered well, without appropriating it or rushing toward the next one.

A brief touch of the dimension and mastery of it are not the same thing. Repeated entries make it possible to recognize more reliably what belongs to the formless dimension itself and what was a transitional residue of *rūpa*, tension, or clinging. A successful entry does not mean that clinging to *rūpa* has been abandoned once and for all.

The Dimension of All-Pervading Infinite Consciousness

In [SN 16.9](#), the transition is described briefly: having completely transcended the dimension of boundless space and perceiving “consciousness is boundless,” the practitioner enters and remains in the dimension of infinite consciousness.

From Space to Consciousness

The dimension of boundless space should first become stable and unfold sufficiently. The transition begins with a turn from space toward the process of knowing itself: it becomes clear that space is known, and attention turns toward awareness itself.

At first, the consciousness element (*viññāṇa-dhātu*) may be recognized. This is not yet the dimension of infinite consciousness: the element may become discernible without a transition into the corresponding *arūpa-āyatana*.

During the transition, space ceases to be the support and an “awareness of awareness” arises: consciousness seems to loop back on itself. This is already an initial stage of the dimension of infinite consciousness. When craving is present, consciousness may be experienced as a powerful “thermonuclear reactor.”

One Way of Entering: Catching the Arising of Contact

First, boundless space is clearly recognized as the present support. Then it becomes evident that this support too is conditioned: space is known, which means attention can turn from space itself toward the process of knowing and awareness. The consciousness element (*viññāṇa-dhātu*) may become discernible. If the transition is sufficiently deep, the stage of “awareness of awareness” may pass quickly and collapse into awareness alone.

Next, one catches the moment just before *phassa* arises and, through perception, enters the very process of contact arising. A vast unified field of contacts, without a center, then opens. This is how entry into the dimension of infinite all-pervading consciousness occurs.

In a deeply unfolded dimension of boundless space, a unified field of information may be experienced, while the connections within it are not yet distinguishable. As the transition to the dimension of infinite consciousness proceeds, space fades: first a single mental contact becomes distinguishable, then the entire field of contacts and interconnections. With further deepening, individual contacts cease to stand out, the interconnections are known as a single field, and everything is experienced as all-pervading infinite consciousness.

As the dimension opens, the multitude of contacts is no longer perceived as a set of separate events. The whole field opens simultaneously as a single all-pervading network without center or edge, beyond space and time. Loosely, it can be compared to a mycelium.

There is no division into “my” consciousness and the consciousness of “others”: everything opens as one boundless field of contacts.

The intensity of this experience may increase as far as bright radiance or a sense of plasma. This is a figurative description of experience, not a literal account of what is happening. What remains essential is that infinite consciousness opens as an impersonal, conditioned, and interdependent process, not as a separate “I” or entity.

At the beginning of the dimension, *vedanā* may still remain. As it deepens, feeling, including neutral feeling, fades as disengagement from feeling becomes increasingly complete. A contact or external signal may still become distinguishable, but it no longer unfolds further into pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral *vedanā*.

Consciousness Without a Separate Observer

When the fading and conditionality of consciousness itself are seen clearly, the dimension of infinite consciousness can easily be mistaken for *Nibbāna*. Yet describing infinite consciousness itself as an “observer” or a separate *attā* is inaccurate here.

In a deeply unfolded dimension, there is no separate subject looking at the field of consciousness from outside, and no division into a separate “I” and separate “others.” One all-pervading network of contacts is experienced: not “my consciousness observes the network,” but consciousness itself unfolds as a common field of contacts.

Separateness appears only in the further conditioned unfolding of experience. In the chain nourished by *avijjā*, at the level of *nāma-rūpa*, separate entities and processes come to be distinguished, after which they may be appropriated as “I,” “mine,” and “other.” It is therefore important here to see the conditionality both of consciousness itself and of the subsequent arising.

The Dimension of Nothingness

In [SN 16.9](#), after completely transcending the dimension of infinite consciousness, the practitioner perceives “there is nothing” and enters the dimension of nothingness.

From Consciousness to Nothingness

In [SN 36.11](#), the cessation of the perception of the dimension of infinite consciousness is explicitly stated in connection with the dimension of nothingness. In practice, the former support fades, and “there is nothing” becomes predominant.

As the dimension of infinite consciousness (*viññāṇañcāyatana*) comes to an end, the unified field of consciousness begins to fade: fewer and fewer contacts remain distinguishable until consciousness ceases to manifest. This is still the fading of the preceding attainment, not yet the dimension of nothingness.

The transition to the dimension of nothingness (*ākāṅkṣāyatana*) begins with the absence of consciousness. Then what still remains discernible also ceases to manifest. As the attainment deepens, only subtle perception of the absence of everything remains: “there is nothing.” Thus *ākāṅkṣāyatana* opens.

Do Not Confuse It with *Nibbāna*

After form, space, and infinite consciousness have been relinquished as supports, the peace may become so deep that “there is nothing” is easily mistaken for final cessation. But

the sequence of attainments continues with the dimension of neither-perception-nor-non-perception and then with the cessation of perception and feeling. The dimension of nothingness remains a conditioned attainment.

The Dimension of Neither-Perception-nor-Non-Perception

TODO

What Remains When the Dimension of Neither-Perception-nor-Non-Perception Fades

As the dimension of neither-perception-nor-non-perception (*nevasaññānāsaññāyatana*) fades, even the extremely subtle perception ceases. Yet the potential for perception to arise and for further becoming still remains.

The pull toward renewed arising or continuation manifests as *bhava-taṇhā*. It does not necessarily take the form of the thought “I want to exist,” but may be an almost imperceptible impulse: “may there be,” “may it continue,” “may it manifest.”

When it is clear that further becoming is conditioned, impermanent, and *dukkha*, the opposite impulse may arise: instead of “may there be,” “may there not be.” This is how *vibhava-taṇhā* manifests.

If craving turns toward cessation itself - “I want *nirodha*,” “may everything cease” - this is *nirodha-taṇhā*.

Three Meanings of *nirodha*

Meaning	What is meant
Cessation in <i>paṭiccasamuppāda</i>	With the cessation of a condition, the corresponding part of the chain ceases; for example, without <i>taṇhā</i> , <i>upādāna</i> is not nourished.
<i>Nibbāna</i> as cessation	The cessation of craving, clinging, greed, hatred, and delusion; not a temporary collapse of experience.
<i>Saññāvedayitanirodha</i>	The meditative cessation of perception and feeling, a subtle attainment that should not be confused with final liberation.

Do Not Form Intention Toward Either Existence or Non-existence

MN 140 states the decisive principle: *neva taṃ abhisankharoti, na abhisāñceti* *bhavāya vā vibhavāya vā* - not to form and not to direct intention toward either *bhava* or *vibhava*. When the very formation of further becoming ceases, there is nothing left to sustain a new unfolding of experience. *Nirodha* does not arise from the intention “to make it cease,” but becomes possible when the sustaining of craving ceases.

The cessation of perception and feeling is attained after fully transcending the dimension of neither-perception-nor-non-perception. It should not be confused with the broader meaning of *nirodha*, which in the suttas also denotes the cessation of particular processes, craving, or suffering. In MN 43, the cessation of perception and feeling is explicitly distinguished from death: vitality and heat remain, and the faculties are not destroyed.

After any deep state, the criterion is one: are *taṇhā*, *māna*, *dosa*, fear, clinging, and ignorance decreasing?

Three Doors to the Unconditioned

TODO: SN 43.4 identifies emptiness concentration (suññata), signless concentration (animitta), and undirected concentration (appaṇihita) as a path to the unconditioned.

20. Formal Practice and Practice in Daily Life

Refuge in the Three Jewels

Taking refuge in the Buddha, Dhamma, and Sangha means consciously choosing the Three Jewels as the central orientation of one's life and practice. The Buddha is seen as the teacher who discovered and fully realized the path; the Dhamma as the teaching and practice leading to the cessation of *dukkha*; and the noble Sangha as the example of those who have realized the path. A community of practitioners can provide spiritual support and companionship in practice.

In SN 45.2, good friendship, companionship, and association are called the whole of the spiritual life, because they create favorable conditions for developing the Noble Eightfold Path. A good friend can help one hear the Dhamma, see one's mistakes, and continue practicing, but each person must still understand and walk the path for themselves.

Refuge strengthens confidence, inspiration, and stability, especially amid fear, doubt, or loss of direction. In SN 11.3, recollection of the Buddha, Dhamma, and Sangha helps overcome fear. In AN 11.11, recollection of the Buddha straightens the mind, followed by joy, tranquility, and collectedness.

The Dhamma and Vinaya as Teacher

In DN 16, the Buddha says that after his departure the Dhamma and Vinaya will be the teacher of his followers. This does not mean blindly following systems or one's own ideas. Practice rests on the Dhamma, discipline, and the testing of fruits: what leads to the reduction of *lobha*, *dosa*, and *moha*, to clarity and gentleness, and to liberation from *dukkha*?

It is therefore useful to observe one's own experience attentively: notice which conditions make the mind clearer, calmer, and kinder, and which lead to heaviness and hindrances. Such investigation remains within the Dhamma: it seeks not a special state, but conditions under which the chain receives less nourishment.

Technique and the Conditions of Practice

In MN 39, the four jhānas are presented as part of gradual training. Their preparation consists of purity of conduct and livelihood, guarding the sense doors, moderation in eating, wakefulness, mindfulness and clear comprehension, seclusion, and abandonment of the five hindrances.

This sequence should not be understood as a rigid staircase on which each stage must be fully mastered before the next is approached. It shows that *samādhi* does not arise from a single meditation technique, but rests on one's whole way of life and practice. Many conditions for collectedness are formed outside the meditation session and then support practice within it. For a layperson, wakefulness and diligence do not mean deliberate sleep deprivation or exhaustion. What matters is moderation, clarity, and a reasonable attitude toward the body, not trying to force collectedness through excessive tension.

When overloaded, after a break in practice, or when prolonged sitting turns into a struggle against oneself, it is wiser to begin with short but regular sessions. Their length can gradually increase as stability develops naturally.

A technique is not an end in itself. Its usefulness is determined by whether *lobha*, *dosa*, and *moha* lessen; whether the hindrances and the arising of *taṇhā* after *vedanā* are recognized more clearly; whether collectedness strengthens; and whether clinging to experiences weakens.

Tuning Effort

Meditation should not become the forceful holding of an object, but neither is it passive waiting for calm. In [AN 6.55](#), effort is compared to tuning strings: excessive tension leads to restlessness, while insufficient energy leads to dullness. Effort is adjusted so that the mind remains alert but not constricted.

A pleasant bodily sensation may sometimes serve as a support for calming. If relaxation turns into drowsiness, it may help to straighten up or half-open the eyes; if tension arises, relax control and allow breathing to proceed naturally.

A useful image: attention can rest on a bodily sensation as a seal rests on the shore, steady and relaxed, without trying to squeeze a desired state out of what is happening.

Do Not Measure Practice Only by Attainments

Meditation should not be regarded as unsuccessful merely because no *jhāna*, rapture, or especially clear state arose. If the right direction was maintained, distractions noticed, hindrances recognized, and attention returned to the meditation object, the session was not fruitless. Sometimes its result lies not in an unusual experience, but in distraction being seen more clearly, a habitual reaction not being continued, or the mind calming even briefly. Skill gradually develops, and the hindrances are recognized earlier and more precisely.

Jhānas are conditioned: they arise not merely at the practitioner's wish, but when the necessary conditions come together and the hindrances temporarily subside. A person may work honestly every day without receiving wages after every single hour. Likewise, especially calm and deep meditation may be prepared by many ordinary and sometimes difficult sessions. The task is therefore not to squeeze a desired result out of each meditation, but patiently to cultivate its conditions without craving and frustration.

If exhaustion, severe tension, or deterioration regularly remain after practice, this should not be justified by saying "every session is useful." The duration, object, or method should be reconsidered.

It may also be useful to imagine that this is the last opportunity to practice in this life. If only one hour remained, would it be worth spending it on habitual fantasies, arguments, and plans? This recollection should not produce fear or tension. Its purpose is to cut through what is secondary and return to practice.

In [AN 6.19](#), the Buddha offers an even sharper recollection of death: practice with the understanding that life may last only until the next morsel of food, or the next in-breath and out-breath. The value of this reflection is not gloom, but the development of urgency and heedfulness.

Patience Does Not Mean Inaction

When a condition cannot presently be changed without harm, patience helps one not add a second dart to pain. But when danger, overload, or an unwholesome situation can reasonably be changed, such action is also part of practice.

Accepting the fact "this is how it is now" therefore does not mean deciding "let it remain this way." Mindfulness helps one see what is happening more clearly and choose the less

harmful course.

Monasticism and Lay Life

Monasticism can create favorable conditions for practice: simplifying daily life, reducing distractions, and supporting ethical discipline. Monastic status by itself, however, does not liberate and does not replace development of the Noble Eightfold Path.

Ordination also does not erase previous *kamma* or cancel the possible ripening of its results. Lay life in itself does not obstruct practice. It can provide varied conditions for training and practice in everyday activities and in relationships with different people. The task is to organize life so that these conditions become a field of practice rather than crowding practice out.

In the society of the Buddha's time, a person's life was determined to a great extent by family, household duties, and social position. Today many people can organize their work, relationships, and way of life more freely, leaving enough space for practice.

The Path Is Not About Sainthood

The cessation of *dukkha* should not be understood as constructing a "saintly" identity in the ordinary religious sense: a special personality, a special spiritual entity, or an ideal image of a practitioner. In the Dhamma, the point is not to create a new spiritual image, but to end craving, clinging, becoming, and ignorance.

Ethical conduct is necessary as a condition of the path: without it, the mind is full of remorse, conflict, and agitation. Unwholesome actions create conditions that obstruct practice. But the goal of the path is not to construct a new identity, "I am holy" or "I am realized." The goal is that greed, hatred, and delusion no longer govern the mind and the chain of suffering is no longer fed.

Clear Comprehension in Activity

While walking, eating, conversing, working, and resting, it is useful to notice not only the action itself, but its appropriateness: why am I doing this, does it lead to clarity or hindrances, has mindfulness been lost, and is the action driven by craving, irritation, or distraction?

Posture for Sitting Meditation

In [MN 10](#), the Buddha describes the beginning of sitting meditation as follows:

*araññagato vā rukkhamūlagato vā suññāgāragato vā nisīdati, pallaṅkaṃ ābhujitvā,
ujum kāyaṃ paṇidhāya, parimukhaṃ satim upaṭṭhapetvā*

That is, the practitioner goes to a forest, the root of a tree, or an empty shelter; sits down with the legs folded in *pallaṅka*; holds the body upright; and establishes mindfulness to the fore.

Pallaṅkaṃ ābhujitvā indicates sitting with the legs crossed and literally suggests folding the legs into a cross-legged posture. More important, however, are suitable conditions for practice: a quiet or secluded place, a stable and comfortable posture, an upright back, and mindfulness. If the body does not permit cross-legged sitting without pain and unnecessary tension, another posture may be used, such as sitting on a chair.

Practice in the Moment

When the mind has been caught by something, three questions are enough:

1. What was the *phassa*?
2. What *vedanā* arose?

3. What *taṇhā* is beginning to stir?

If there is a little more clarity, add:

4. What is the mind clinging to?
5. What kind of “I” is being born now?
6. What will follow from it?

Retrospective Practice

Choose a single episode and break it down:

- Contact.
- Feeling.
- Craving.
- Clinging.
- Becoming.
- Birth of a role.
- Cost of the role.
- Where could the chain have been left unfed?

Over time, the mind begins to recognize the chain earlier.

21. Worksheets

Worksheet 1: the Unpleasant

1. What happened?
2. What was the *phassa*?
3. What was the *vedanā*?
4. What was the *taṇhā*?
5. What does the mind want to obtain from the object or action: relief, control, aliveness, flow, belonging, fantasy, or escape from dissatisfaction?
6. What happens to the feeling, bodily impulse, and mental story if the pull is not given its habitual nourishment for a short time?
7. What is the *upādāna*?
8. What is the *bhava*?
9. What “I” was born?
10. What is the cost of this state?
11. Where can the chain be opened?

Worksheet 2: the Pleasant

1. What pleasant experience arose?
2. How did the body feel it?
3. Was there a wish to prolong, repeat, or secure it?
4. What self-image did the mind begin to construct?
5. Did dependence on recognition, taste, success, or a state arise?
6. Can the pleasant be allowed to end without residual hunger?

Worksheet 3: Desire

1. What does the desire promise?
2. What does it want to remove or obtain?
3. Are fatigue, anxiety, boredom, loneliness, or pain behind it?
4. What will happen if it is indulged automatically?
5. What will happen if it is suppressed?

6. What does the middle way look like: understand, do not feed, choose?

Worksheet 4: *samādhī*

1. Which hindrance was predominant before practice?
2. Was the mind calming, or being forcibly constricted?
3. Did pleasantness arise naturally, or was the mind trying to reproduce it?
4. Did clarity remain together with calm?
5. Which conditions helped collectedness arise?
6. Which hindrances were absent, and which merely quieted temporarily?
7. After practice, did it become easier to recognize *vedanā* - *taṇhā*?
8. Did clinging to repetition, comparison, attainment, or status arise?
9. What should be developed next without turning practice into a hunt for a state?

Worksheet 5: Speech and Action

This worksheet follows the general logic of [MN 61](#): examine an action before, during, and after it.

Before the Action

1. What am I about to say or do?
2. What intention leads the action: goodwill, protection, irritation, the desire to win, to obtain approval, or to avoid the unpleasant?
3. Could the action cause harm to me, another person, or both?
4. Can a reasonable aim be achieved in a less harmful way?

During the Action

5. What is happening in body and mind right now?
6. Are craving, hostility, or confusion becoming stronger?
7. What consequences are already visible?
8. Should I continue, change the manner of acting, or stop?

After the Action

9. What are the actual consequences for me, other people, and relationships?
10. Did they match what the mind expected?
11. If the action was unwholesome, what should be acknowledged, repaired, or not repeated?
12. What condition should be changed before a similar situation in the future?

22. Short Reminders

Five Frequent Recollections

[AN 5.57](#) lists five themes for frequent recollection:

- I am subject to aging and have not gone beyond aging;
- I am subject to illness and have not gone beyond illness;

- I am subject to death and have not gone beyond death;
- I must be separated from everything dear and pleasing to me;
- I am the heir of my actions: whatever I do, wholesome or unwholesome, will become my inheritance.

These recollections serve sobriety: they weaken heedlessness and help one choose actions of body, speech, and mind more carefully.

A *vedanā* Reminder

The pleasant is not mine.

The unpleasant is not mine.

The neutral is not mine.

But this is not a denial of experience. It is seeing that feeling arises through conditions and ceases through conditions.

A *taṇhā* Reminder

Taṇhā says:

- “more”;
- “remove it”;
- “hold it”;
- “prove it”;
- “become”;
- “disappear.”

An *upādāna* Reminder

Where is “mine”?

- being right;
- my image;
- my pleasure;
- my pain;
- my path;
- my realization;
- my opinion;
- my control.

A *bhava* Reminder

What mode of existence has switched on?

- “I, the offended one”;
- “I, the defender”;
- “I, the winner”;
- “I, the victim”;
- “I, the loved one”;
- “I, the special one”;
- “I, the controller”;
- “I, the practitioner.”

23. Glossary of Pali Terms

Adosa

Non-hatred: the absence of aversion, hostility, and the urge to reject. It is one of the three wholesome roots, together with *alobha* and *amoha*. *Adosa* does not mean weakness, submission, or the loss of boundaries. It means that the mind does not wish to harm, humiliate, suppress, or destroy. It is the opposite of *dosa*.

Ahaṅkāra

“I-making”: identification and the appropriation of experience as “this is me.” It is close in meaning to the formula *eso’ham asmi*, “this I am.”

Anattā

Not-self, impersonality. This is not the nihilistic assertion that “nothing exists.” It means that no independent, permanent, governing self can be found in the aggregates or in conditioned processes.

Anusaya

An underlying tendency or latent disposition. It need not be present as an overt thought or emotion, but may manifest when suitable conditions arise. Pleasant *vedanā* can sustain the underlying tendency to passion, unpleasant *vedanā* the tendency to aversion, and neutral *vedanā* the tendency to ignorance.

Seven are distinguished: sensual attraction, aversion, views, doubt, conceit, attraction to becoming, and ignorance.

Anicca

Impermanence. Whatever has arisen changes and ceases.

Ariyasacca

A noble truth, “noble” in origin and scope. It is not merely a proposition, but something to be fully understood, abandoned, realized, or developed.

Arūpa āyatana

Formless dimensions: boundless space, infinite consciousness, nothingness, and neither-perception-nor-non-perception. These are subtle conditioned attainments, not Nibbāna.

Asaṅkhata

The unmade, the unconditioned. It is the opposite of *saṅkhata*: made, compounded, conditioned.

Āsavā

Influxes, deep corrupting currents: sensuality, becoming, and ignorance. *Āsavakkhaya* means the cessation or exhaustion of these influxes.

Ātāpī

Diligent, ardent, energetic. The term uses the image of heat, but does not imply self-torment. It points to bright, sustained energy that does not let the mind drift away or feed the unwholesome, and that maintains clarity.

Attavādupādāna

Clinging to a doctrine or idea of self. This does not necessarily take the crude form “I am the body.” It can take subtler forms: “I am consciousness,” “I am pure knowing,” or “Nibbāna is my true self.” In practice, it is important to see not only the content of such an idea, but also the craving for existence that seeks a new foothold.

Avijjā

Ignorance. It is not merely a lack of information, but distorted seeing: taking the impermanent as permanent, the unsatisfactory as satisfactory, the impersonal as personal, and the unattractive as beautiful.

Avippaṭisāra

Absence of remorse. It arises when conduct leaves no unwholesome trace in the mind and supports joy and collectedness.

Bhava

Becoming, existence. In dependent origination it is conditioned by clinging and conditions birth. Sensual, form, and formless becoming are distinguished. In present experience, the mechanism of becoming can be seen in how an appropriated and sustained coloration of *citta* becomes established as “I am such-and-such.”

Bhāvanā

Development or cultivation of the conditions of the path. It is neither mechanical production nor violence against oneself. One purifies conduct, directs attention, strengthens *sati*, gathers the mind, and develops wise seeing. As conditions change, experience changes.

Cetanā

Intention or volitional impulse. It directs action by body, speech, and mind. In experience it may be noticed as: “now I will answer,” “now I will get what I want,” or “now I will hold on to this.”

Dhamma

The Buddha’s teaching, truth, a phenomenon, or the lawfulness of experience. Practically, it is what leads toward the cessation of *dukkha*. The word may also refer to psychophysical phenomena; its meaning depends on context.

Dosa

Aversion, rejection, irritation, or hostility. It is one of the three unwholesome roots, together with *lobha* and *moha*. Under *dosa*, the mind wants to remove, suppress, strike, destroy, or reject an unpleasant object. This should be distinguished from clearly discerning harm: one can set boundaries or stop an unwholesome action without hatred. *Dosa* feeds harshness, hostility, harsh speech, inner violence, and further *dukkha*.

Dukkha

Unsatisfactoriness, painfulness, instability of the conditioned, suffering. It is not limited to gross pain. It also includes the subtler unreliability of everything that arises through conditions, changes, and disintegrates.

Indriya-saṃvara

Restraint of the sense faculties. This is not closing oneself off from life, but wisely caring for which contacts are admitted and how the mind engages with them.

Jarāmaraṇa

Aging-and-death. In the standard formula of dependent origination, this is the aging and death of a being that has been born, together with sorrow, pain, dejection, and despair. On the small scale, every role loses its support and brings anxiety, fatigue, regret, and *dukkha*.

Jāti

Birth. In the standard formula of dependent origination, the appearance of a being, the manifestation of the aggregates, and the acquisition of the sense fields. On the small scale, the birth of a particular “I-state.”

Jhāna

Meditative collectedness. The standard formula describes four *rūpa jhānas*. They are valuable for purifying and stabilizing the mind, but are not to be made into objects of clinging.

Khandhā

The five aggregates: *rūpa*, *vedanā*, *saññā*, *saṅkhārā*, and *viññāṇa*. They become objects of clinging when taken as “I” or “mine.”

Lobha

Greed, avarice, grasping desire. It is one of the three unwholesome roots, together with *dosa* and *moha*, and is closely related to *taṇhā* and *rāga*. Under *lobha*, the mind reaches toward an object and wants to obtain it, retain it, repeat it, or make it “mine.” This should be distinguished from a wholesome wish to practice. The wish to abandon the unwholesome, develop the path, and understand the Dhamma may be part of right effort. *Lobha*, by contrast, feeds appropriation, clinging, and further *bhava*.

Magga

The path. In the framework of the early suttas, this is the Noble Eightfold Path, cultivated through ethics, collectedness, and wisdom.

Mamaṅkāra

“Mine-making”: appropriating experience as “this is mine.” It corresponds to the formula *etaṃ mama*, “this is mine.”

Māna

Conceit and subtle comparison organized around “I”: “I am,” “I am superior,” “I am inferior,” “I am equal,” or “I understood.” It is not limited to gross pride, but includes the subtle habit of relating experience to a center called “I.”

Mettā

Goodwill, loving-kindness: wishing for another’s welfare without self-interest.

Moha

Delusion, confusion, obscuration, or misapprehension. It is one of the three unwholesome roots, together with *lobha* and *dosa*. It is not merely a lack of information, but a distortion in which the impermanent appears stable, the conditioned appears independent, and the impersonal is taken as “I” or “mine.” It is closely related to *avijjā*. In this document, *avijjā* refers more broadly to ignorance of the Four Noble Truths and conditionality, while *moha* often denotes the concrete obscuration and confusion from which unwholesome intentions of body, speech, and mind arise.

Muditā

Appreciative joy in the welfare, success, or happiness of others, without envy or appropriation.

Nāma-rūpa

Name-and-form, the psychophysical complex. *Nāma* includes feeling, perception, intention, contact, and attention; *rūpa* is material form.

Nibbāna

The unborn, unoriginated, unmade; liberation, the extinguishing of craving, hatred, and ignorance. It is not an ordinary state that can be appropriated or held.

Nibbidā

Disenchantment, disillusionment, or detachment from clinging to the conditioned. It is not depression, anhedonia, or disgust with life, but the sober ending of the search for final support where no such support can be found.

Nirodha

Cessation. Depending on context, it may refer to the cessation of a particular link, the cessation of *dukkha*, *Nibbāna*, or the cessation of perception and feeling.

Pamojja

Joy, inspiration, or clear uplift born of a wholesome direction. It is not sensual euphoria, but a healthy enlivening of the mind.

Papañca

Mental proliferation, self-narrative, conceptual multiplication. This is not every instance of thought, but proliferation around “I,” “mine,” and “for me”: elaborating, fantasizing, arguing, comparing, defending, replaying, and constructing worlds. It is fed by *taṇhā*, *māna*, views, and *avijjā*.

It may begin with a small association or assumption when gaps in clear knowing are filled in, and the story that has arisen is then taken as something directly seen.

Paṭinissagga

Relinquishment, letting go. It is not a command imposed by will, but the weakening of grasping through seeing conditions, impermanence, and cessation. When what is held can no longer be taken as a reliable support, clinging loses nourishment.

Phassa

Contact: the meeting of a sense faculty, its object, and the corresponding consciousness. *Vedanā* arises dependent on contact.

Saddhā

Confidence or trust. It is not blind acceptance, but the confidence that motivates practice and verification.

Sakkāya-diṭṭhi

Identity view based on the five aggregates: regarding body, feeling, perception, formations, or consciousness as self, as belonging to self, as contained within self, or as containing self. Practically, it is the appropriation and construction of “I” and “mine.”

Salāyatana

The six sense fields: eye, ear, nose, tongue, body, and mind, together with their corresponding objects.

Sampajañña

Clear comprehension of events, actions, intentions, appropriateness, the state of mind, and relevant conditions. It works closely together with *sati*.

Samudaya

The arising or origin of *dukkha*. In the Four Noble Truths it points primarily to *taṇhā* as the source that sustains suffering.

Saṅkhārā

Formations or formative activities. Depending on context, the word may refer to conditioned phenomena generally, bodily, verbal, and mental formations in dependent origination, or intentions, especially *cetanā*, within the aggregate of formations.

Saññā

Perception and recognition. In coarse experience it distinguishes and recognizes an object, connects it with memory, and participates in labeling. In deep *samādhi*, *saññā* becomes refined to an elementary definiteness of experience without ordinary recognition and conceptualization. The expression *sukhuma-saññā*, subtle perception, is used for this level. In DN 9 the expression *sukhuma-sacca-saññā* is used for subtle forms: subtle, actually present perception.

Saññāvedayitanirodha

The cessation of perception and feeling. This is a particular meditative attainment, not an intellectual idea of emptiness or simple unconsciousness.

Sati

Recollection: returning to the object and framework of practice. It is not vague observation, but a quality that sustains clear knowing of body, feeling, mind, and *dhammā*. Renderings include “mindfulness,” “attentiveness,” and “the capacity for self-awareness.” Here *sati* means recollection: the ability to retain in mind the Dhamma, the direction of the path, and the present task of practice. The rendering “mindfulness” is useful only in part, provided it is not reduced to neutral present-moment awareness.

Taṇhā

Craving. It is not every functional desire, but the clinging pull toward sensual pleasure, becoming, or non-becoming. Its flavor is: “let it be as I want.”

Upādāna

Clinging, appropriation, holding on. *Taṇhā* condenses into “mine”: my view, pleasure, rightness, image, or path. The term is sometimes translated as attachment or grasping, but should be distinguished from wholesome striving. It is the grasping of an object, state, opinion, ritual, or idea of self that sustains further *bhava*.

Upanisā

A supporting condition or proximate support. In [SN 12.23](#), *dukkha* can become a supporting condition for *saddhā* when it is understood as the conditioned unreliability that makes the path necessary.

Upekkhā

Equanimity, even-mindedness, balance. It is not coldness, but stability without clinging or rejection.

Vedanā

Feeling tone: pleasant, unpleasant, or neutral. It is not yet an emotion or a narrative. *Taṇhā* often begins here.

Sāmisa

With worldly, sensual nourishment. In contemplation of *vedanā*, this distinction is applied to pleasant, unpleasant, and neutral feeling. For pleasant feeling, a clear example is pleasure arising on the basis of the five strands of sensual pleasure.

Nirāmisa

Without worldly, sensual nourishment; connected with renunciation. In contemplation of *vedanā*, this distinction is likewise applied to pleasant, unpleasant, and neutral feeling. It does not simply mean “spiritual” as opposed to “bodily,” and it is not limited to *samādhi*.

Vicikicchā

Doubt, uncertainty, or indecision that prevents confident continuation. As a hindrance it clouds the mind and weakens wisdom. In [MN 16](#), doubt concerning the Teacher, the Dhamma, the Saṅgha, or the training obstructs diligence and persistence. As a fetter it is abandoned at stream-entry. The term does not cover every question or inquiry, but rather paralyzing doubt that keeps the mind in indecision and prevents action even when the direction of practice is sufficiently clear.

Vimutti

Liberation: the mind freed from clinging, craving, hostility, and ignorance. It is not a status or self-image, but the cessation of what sustains *dukkha*.

Vinaya

Discipline, training, a canonical division, and a way of maintaining life under conditions that support the path. In a broad practical sense it is not merely a collection of rules, but a form that protects practice from disorder.

Viññāṇa

Consciousness as awareness of an object: visual, auditory, olfactory, gustatory, bodily, or mental. It arises dependent on conditions and is not an independent bearer of experience or a hidden self that owns it.

Virāga

Dispassion, the fading of passion, the cooling of greedy interest in the conditioned. It is not lifelessness or suppression, but the weakening of clinging to what arises and ceases.

Yoniso manasikāra

Wise direction of attention: seeing causes, conditions, arising, and cessation.

24. Supporting Suttas and Sources for Verification

The list below is not exhaustive. These are sources for checking the principal themes.

- [SN 56.11 Dhammacakkappavattana Sutta](#): the Four Noble Truths; in the Pali version, knowledge-and-vision of the four truths is developed through three rounds and twelve aspects.
- [SN 12.2 Vibhaṅga Sutta](#): the expanded formula of dependent origination; bodily, verbal, and mental *saṅkhārā*.
- [SN 12.15 Kaccānagotta Sutta](#): avoiding the extremes of existence and non-existence.
- [SN 12.23 Upanisā Sutta](#): the liberating sequence of conditions from *dukkha* to *saddhā*, *samādhi*, *nibbidā*, *virāga*, and *vimutti*.
- [DN 2 Sāmaññaphala Sutta](#): gradual training through *sīla*, sense restraint, *sati-sampajañña*, contentment, abandonment of the five hindrances, the four *jhānas*, and knowledge of liberation.
- [DN 15 Mahānidāna Sutta](#): the mutual dependence of *viññāṇa* and *nāma-rūpa*, and *nāma-rūpa* as a basis for *phassa*.
- [DN 16 Mahāparinibbāna Sutta](#): the Dhamma and Vinaya as teacher after the Buddha's passing.
- [DN 31 Siṅgālasutta](#): advice to the layperson Sigāla.
- [MN 29 Mahāsāropama Sutta](#): *vimutti* as the heartwood of the holy life: not honor, morality, collectedness, or knowledge in themselves, but liberation of mind.
- [MN 22 Alagaddūpama Sutta](#): the Dhamma as a raft for crossing over, and the danger of grasping the teaching wrongly, like taking a snake by the wrong end.
- [SN 35.28 Ādittapariyāya Sutta](#): seeing the six sense fields as burning with passion, hatred, and delusion gives rise to *nibbidā*, *virāga*, and *vimutti*.
- [MN 28 Mahāhatthipadopamasutta](#): internal and external elements, their impermanence and non-appropriation, and the conditions for the manifestation of the corresponding sense consciousness, *tajjo samannāhāro*.
- [SN 35.23 Sabba Sutta](#): “the all” as the six sense fields of experience.
- [SN 22.59 Anattalakkhaṇa Sutta](#): the five aggregates as *anattā*.
- [SN 22.89 Khemaka Sutta](#): residual “I am” in relation to the five aggregates and the comparison with the scent of a flower.
- [MN 148 Chachakka Sutta](#): the six sextets, contact, feeling, craving, not-self, and the relation of pleasant, unpleasant, and neutral feeling to the tendencies toward passion, aversion, and ignorance.
- [AN 6.63 Nibbedhika Sutta](#): intention as *kamma*; sensuality as passionate intention toward attractive objects.
- [SN 51.13 / SN 51.20](#): *chanda* as one basis for developing collectedness and effort (*idhipāda*).
- [AN 8.53 Gotamī Sutta](#): criteria for what accords with the Dhamma and Vinaya (*Dhamma-Vinaya*).
- [SN 45.8 Magga-vibhaṅga Sutta](#): the Noble Eightfold Path.
- [MN 2 Sabbāsava Sutta](#): different ways of abandoning the *āsavā*: seeing, restraint, use, endurance, avoidance, removal, and development.
- [MN 20 Vitakkasaṅṭhāna Sutta](#): practical methods for working with unwholesome thoughts.
- [MN 5](#): honest diagnosis of stains in the mind, seeing a defilement when it is present and its absence when it is absent.
- [MN 9 Sammādiṭṭhi Sutta](#): right view as understanding a phenomenon, its arising, its cessation, and the path to its cessation; the mutual conditionality of *āsava* and *avijjā*, and the three kinds of *āsava*.
- [MN 18 Madhupiṇḍika Sutta](#): contact, feeling, perception, thought, and *papañca*.
- [SN 46.51](#): the nourishment and non-nourishment of the hindrances and awakening factors.

- [SN 46.53](#): balancing the factors: investigation, energy, and joy are needed during sluggishness; tranquility, collectedness, and equanimity during agitation.
- [SN 4.4](#): wise direction of attention and right effort as a concise statement of the path's working heart.
- [SN 4.5](#): the Dhamma is good in the beginning, good in the middle, and good in the end.
- [SN 4.7](#): an example of practice after walking meditation: the lion's posture, mindfulness, clear comprehension, and attention to the time for rising.
- [AN 11.1](#) / [AN 11.2](#): virtue, absence of remorse, joy, tranquility, collectedness, knowledge-and-vision, and liberation.
- [AN 10.13](#): the ten fetters (*saṃyojana*) and their relation to the stages of awakening.
- [MN 10](#) / [DN 22 Satipaṭṭhāna](#): the four establishments of mindfulness, the five hindrances, and the seven awakening factors as part of contemplating *dhammā*; also the standard formula for seated meditation: a suitable place, *pallāṅkam*, an upright back, and established mindfulness.
- [MN 62 Mahārāhulovādasutta](#): internal and external elements and the development of a mind like earth, water, fire, air, and space, which is not seized by pleasant or unpleasant contacts.
- [MN 118 Ānāpānasati Sutta](#): breathing, the four establishments of mindfulness, and the seven awakening factors.
- [MN 119 Kāyagatāsati Sutta](#): mindfulness of the body and the description of the four jhānas in the context of bodily mindfulness and collectedness.
- [Iti 43](#) / [Ud 8.3](#): the unborn, unoriginated, unmade.
- [MN 26 Ariyapariyesanā Sutta](#): the noble search and the limitations of formless attainments as a final goal.
- [MN 43 Mahāvedalla Sutta](#): the interconnection of feeling, perception, and consciousness; questions concerning the cessation of perception and feeling.
- [MN 121 Cūḷasuññata Sutta](#): gradual abiding in emptiness.
- [MN 106 Āneñjasappāya Sutta](#): the path to the imperturbable and subtle meditative supports.
- [DN 1 Brahmajāla Sutta](#): a broad survey of speculative views.
- [MN 13 Mahādukkhakkhandha Sutta](#): gratification, danger, and escape in relation to sensual pleasures.
- [MN 19 Dvedhāvitakka Sutta](#): two directions of thought and the mind's habitual inclination.
- [MN 21 Kakacūpama Sutta](#): maintaining goodwill and freedom from inner hatred in the face of abuse.
- [MN 36 Mahāsaccaka Sutta](#): the happiness of the first jhāna, which need not be feared.
- [MN 38 Mahātaṇhāsankhaya Sutta](#): consciousness arises dependent on conditions and is not an unchanging entity.
- [MN 41 Sāleyyaka Sutta](#): unwholesome and wholesome conduct by body, speech, and mind.
- [MN 61 Ambalaṭṭhikarāhulovāda Sutta](#): examining an action before, during, and after it.
- [MN 64 Mahāmālūkyā Sutta](#): underlying tendencies, the lower fetters, and their abandonment.
- [MN 75 Māgaṇḍiya Sutta](#): the image of scratching sores and liberation from sensual craving.
- [MN 117 Mahācattārīsaka Sutta](#): right and wrong path factors, and right collectedness with its seven supports.
- [SN 35.63 Paṭhamamigajāla Sutta](#): craving as a companion even in external solitude.
- [SN 36.6 Salla Sutta](#): the first and second darts.

- [SN 47.5 Kusalarāsi Sutta](#): the five hindrances as the mass of the unwholesome and the four establishments of mindfulness as the mass of the wholesome.
- [AN 4.41 Samādhībhāvanā Sutta](#): four purposes for developing collectedness.
- [AN 4.123 Paṭhamanānākaṇṇa Sutta](#): clinging to jhāna and the rebirth conditioned by it.
- [AN 4.162 Vitthāra Sutta](#): painful and pleasant modes of practice.
- [AN 4.170 Yuganaddha Sutta](#): different relations between tranquility and insight.
- [AN 5.177 Vanijjā Sutta](#): five kinds of trade a lay follower should avoid.
- [AN 6.19 Paṭhamamaraṇassati Sutta](#): recollection of death and a sense of urgency.
- [AN 6.61 Majjhe Sutta](#): craving as the seamstress that stitches becoming together.
- [AN 7.11 Paṭhamaanusaya Sutta](#): the seven underlying tendencies.
- [AN 9.35 Gāvūpamā Sutta](#): mastering an attained basis without moving on prematurely.
- [AN 9.36 Jhāna Sutta](#): jhāna and the first three formless attainments as bases for liberating vision.
- [Sn̐p 1.8 Mettā Sutta](#): goodwill, freedom from contempt, and not wishing suffering upon another.
- [Dhp 5](#): hostility is not calmed by hostility.
- [Dhp 334–336, 347](#): images of a creeping vine, grass growing back, and a spider in its own web.
- [SN 11.3 Dhajagga Sutta](#): recollection of the Buddha, Dhamma, and Saṅgha as a support in the face of fear.
- [AN 11.11 Paṭhama Mahānāma Sutta](#): recollection of the Buddha, straightening the mind, joy, tranquility, and collectedness.
- [Iti 50 Mūla Sutta](#): the three unwholesome roots: *lobha*, *dosa*, and *moha*.
- [SN 35.82 Lokapañhā Sutta](#): the “world” as arising and ceasing sense fields, consciousness, contact, and feeling.
- [AN 10.61 Avijjā Sutta](#): no beginning of ignorance can be discovered, but the conditions that feed it can be discerned.
- [AN 10.72 Kaṇṭaka Sutta](#): sound as a “thorn” for the first jhāna.
- [MN 135 Cūḷakammavibhaṅga Sutta](#): inheriting the consequences of one’s own actions.
- [MN 136 Mahākammavibhaṅga Sutta](#): the complexity of the ripening of *kamma* and the danger of mechanical conclusions.
- [SN 12.38 Cetanā Sutta](#): intention, planning, and sustained tendencies as conditions supporting further becoming.
- [SN 36.21 Sīvaka Sutta](#): not every feeling is conditioned solely by past *kamma*.
- [MN 39 Mahāassapura Sutta](#): gradual training, abandonment of the hindrances, and the four jhānas.
- [AN 6.55 Soṇa Sutta](#): tuning effort through the image of a string’s tension.
- [AN 9.7 Sutavā Sutta](#): actions an arahant monk is incapable of performing intentionally.
- [SN 5.2 Somā Sutta](#): women’s capacity for liberation and the distinction between a conventional designation and an appropriated identity.
- [SN 22.1 Nakulapīṭṭhi Sutta](#): the fourfold formula of *sakkāya-diṭṭhi* applied to each of the five aggregates.
- [MN 95 Caṅkīṣutta](#): the limitations of faith, preference, oral tradition, reasoning, and an accepted view, together with the path to direct knowledge.
- [AN 4.180 Mahāpadesasutta](#): the four great references for evaluating a report attributed to the Buddha, the Saṅgha, or learned elders.
- [MN 70 Kīṭāgiri Sutta](#): seven kinds of noble disciples, including one liberated by wisdom.
- [Dhp 19–20](#): textual knowledge without practice, and a little knowledge embodied in life.

- [AN 5.51 Āvaraṇa Sutta](#): the five hindrances as states that weaken wisdom and obstruct understanding one's own welfare, the welfare of others, and the welfare of both.
- [AN 5.57 Abhiṇhapaccavekkhitabbaṭṭhāna Sutta](#): five themes for frequent reflection: aging, illness, death, separation from what is dear, and recollection that one is heir to one's actions.
- [AN 7.65 Hirīottappa Sutta](#): *hiri* and *ottappa* as conditions for guarding the senses.
- [SN 22.56 Upādānaparipavatta Sutta](#): the aggregate of *saṅkhārā* as six classes of intention.
- [SN 45.2 Upaḍḍha Sutta](#): good friendship, companionship, and association as a condition for developing the Noble Eightfold Path.
- [MN 16 Cetokhila Sutta](#): doubt concerning the Teacher, the Dhamma, the Saṅgha, and the training as an obstacle to diligence and progress.
- [MN 109 Mahāpuṇṇama Sutta](#): the five clinging-aggregates and the error of searching for a separate "self" after recognizing the five aggregates as "not self."
- [SN 16.9 Jhānābhiñña Sutta](#): the sequence of the jhānas and formless dimensions, including the transition from boundless space to boundless consciousness and onward to the dimension of nothingness.
- [SN 36.11 Rahogata Sutta](#): the successive cessation of supports, including the cessation of the perception of infinite consciousness in the dimension of nothingness.
- [SN 43.4 Suññatasamādhī Sutta](#): emptiness concentration, signless concentration, and undirected concentration as doors to the unconditioned.
- [SN 12.67 Naḷakalāpī Sutta](#): the mutual conditionality of *viññāṇa* and *nāma-rūpa*, compared to two bundles of reeds supporting each other.
- [SN 40.5 Ākāśānañcāyatanapañhā Sutta](#): Moggallāna's entry into the dimension of boundless space and the instruction to become established in it.
- [DN 21 Sakkapañha Sutta](#): the criterion for bodily and verbal conduct and seeking; the sequence *papañcasaññāsaṅkhā* → *vitakka* → *chanda* → *piyāppiya* → *issā-macchariya* and the further unfolding of conflict.
- [DN 9 Poṭṭhapāda Sutta](#): the progressive refinement of *saññā*, *sukhuma-sacca-saññā*, the limit of perception, and the cessation of new construction. It has a Chinese parallel, [DĀ 28](#), which also contains the dimension of neither-perception-nor-non-perception.
- [DN 33 Saṅgīti Sutta](#): various triads of craving, including *rūpa-taṇhā*, *arūpa-taṇhā*, and *nirodha-taṇhā*.
- [SN 36.31 Nirāmisa Sutta](#): the distinction between *sāmisa* and *nirāmisa* for *pīti*, *sukha*, *upekkhā*, and liberation; the comparison between sensual pleasure, jhānic pleasure, and a deeper liberation.
- [MN 140 Dhātuvibhaṅga Sutta](#): the six elements, the formless attainments examined as conditioned, and the principle of not forming intention toward either *bhava* or *vibhava*.

Useful Materials for Critical Comparison

The books and other materials used in preparing these notes are listed below.

YouTube channels

- [Kalyana Dhamma](#): sutta analyses and practical explanations.
- [ISKONNY BUDDHA](#): valuable original materials and interpretations 🌸

Individual playlists

- [A Course on Early Buddhist Meditation](#), Bhante Sujato.
- [Dependent Origination in Early Buddhism](#), Ajahn Brahmali and Bhante Sujato.
- [Mahāsatiṭṭhāna Sutta](#), Bhante Sujato.
- [Paṭiccasamuppāda: Dependent Origination](#), Ajahn Brahmali.
- [Bhante Devamitta, Satipaṭṭhāna](#).

Books and texts

- Bhikkhu Sujato, *Satipaṭṭhāna Mūla: The Root Focuses of Mindfulness*: a comparative study of early versions of the teaching on the four *satipaṭṭhānas* and a reconstruction of their proposed common basis.
- Bhikkhu Sujato, *A History of Mindfulness*: the history of *satipaṭṭhāna*, the relationship between *samatha* and *vipassanā*, and the comparative and historical context of the early texts.
- Bhikkhu Sujato and Bhikkhu Brahmali, *The Authenticity of the Early Buddhist Texts*: arguments for the reliability of the early Buddhist texts and the comparative reading of the Nikāyas and Āgamas.
- Bhikkhu Bodhi, *In the Buddha's Words*: a thematic anthology of suttas from the Pali Canon.
- Bhikkhu P. A. Payutto, *Good, Evil and Beyond: Kamma in the Buddha's Teaching*: an examination of *kamma* as intention, the distinction between *kusala* and *akusala*, the ripening of the results of actions, and the path to the cessation of *kamma*.
- Ṭhānissaro Bhikkhu, *With Each & Every Breath*: a practical guide to breath meditation, working with common difficulties, developing *jhāna*, and using collectedness for insight. Used selectively.
- Bhikkhu Anālayo, *Satipaṭṭhāna Meditation: A Practice Guide*: practical clarifications concerning the four establishments of mindfulness, contemplation of the body, feelings, mind, hindrances, and awakening factors.
- Ajahn Brahm, *Mindfulness, Bliss, and Beyond*: used selectively as a source of practical advice on letting go, the hindrances, sustained attention, and walking meditation. Its model of *nimitta* and the shutting down of the senses is best regarded as a highly specific interpretation.